



DECODING AMBEDKAR

Ideas of Nation and Nation Building

VIVEK KUMAR

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BOYDELL • MANOHAR

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Dedicated to my teachers,

PROF. T.K. OOMMEN

PROF. NANDU RAM

&

PROF. ANAND KUMAR

*who taught me
criticality and reflexivity
in Sociology*

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Preface

This book is an attempt to take the discourse about Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, popularly known as Babasaheb Ambedkar among his followers in India and across the globe, regarding his vast horizon of knowledge production. Through the four essays in this book, we have tried to deconstruct the reductionist approach adopted by mainstream academia and intelligentsia across India to understand Ambedkar. The book has tried to record the erasure of Ambedkar from various academic texts of sociology, history, and literature. It has recorded these phenomena in the media and creative fields like feature films as well. Juxtaposing this process of reductionism and erasure of Ambedkar, this book has tried to probe how Ambedkar has been received and appreciated by international institutions and academicians. How, on the one hand, they have engaged with his writings on various aspects such as society, polity, democracy, and social justice, and on the other hand, how have they hailed his academic writings in their own writings.

The second chapter of the book maps the original and unique theoretical and philosophical insights provided by Ambedkar on Hindu social order with the place of the individual, varna, genesis of caste, and annihilation of caste. He has analysed why the Hindu social order is not an open social order and why this social order should be subservient to the demands of individuals. With his unique conceptualization of 'surplus men', 'surplus women', and imposition of endogamy over exogamy, Ambedkar has propounded a very novel theory of the genesis of the caste

system in India. Further, quoting the French sociologist Tarde's 'law of imitation' as the main cause for the spread of the caste system, Ambedkar has opened a new vantage point for research in this area. Towards the end, the chapter has tried to highlight Ambedkar's scheme to annihilate the caste system by adopting certain measures like practicing inter-caste marriages, questioning the legitimacy of sacred texts of the Hindus, and dismantling the practice of priesthood by a single caste.

The theory of social justice, in general and Dr. Ambedkar's theory of social justice, in particular forms part of the third chapter. Although Ambedkar has not propounded exclusively a theory of social justice, however, taking cues from the basic elements of social justice delineated by thinkers such as Plato and Rawls, this chapter has tried to search for these elements in the thoughts of Ambedkar found in his writings and speeches.

I have identified five characteristics of Ambedkar's theory of social justice. These include one—individuals should be developed, in society, as free and independent agents; two—society should be based on equality, liberty, and fraternity; third—the establishment of true democracy based on social, economic, and political equality; fourth—establishing democracy through constitutional measures; and fifth—dispensing social justice by breaking the monopoly of the so-called upperstrata on political power.

Ambedkar's ideas of nation and nation-building form part of chapter four of the book. This can be a very significant aspect of his academics and intellectual writings. This issue is still relevant in contemporary Indian society and will remain relevant till the Indian society exists. According to the author, it was Ambedkar, along with a few others, who was responsible for highlighting the fact that the Indian nation does not exist, and it is in the process of evolving. He defined what is a nation and how can one define a nation based on individual

rights? How the constitution provides instruments so that a nation can be built. Forgetfulness is another significant element of the nation-building process. This chapter has also recorded how Ambedkar was not in favour of the Partition of India. However, for nation-building, he was very much in favour of self-representation of erstwhile excluded communities like untouchables, tribals, and minorities in the institutions of governance. In the same vein for nation-building, he was very much for the empowerment of women with equal rights at par with men. Ambedkar was not only concerned with the making of a nation, rather he also laid down the principles to keep the unity and integrity of the nation intact in the future. According to Ambedkar, the trinity of equality, liberty, and fraternity must coexist if the nation has to develop. With the aforesaid propositions, conceptualizations, and formulations, Ambedkar has proved himself a sociologist par excellence. On the basis of his larger socio-political and cultural themes, Ambedkar can easily be called one of the founders of Indian Sociology.

The running theme in the book is the unique perspective with which it has been written. We have called this perspective a 'Perspective From Below'. Citing references from Descartes, Locke, Kant, Durkheim, Mills, Berger and Luckmann, Bourdieu, Kuhn, Freire, and a few others, we have evolved a rationale for developing the perspective. And with this perspective, we have taken the whole discourse around Ambedkar and his knowledge production away from the mainstream discourse. We are aware that the mainstream discourse has led the debates and discussions around Ambedkar only by treating him as a Dalit leader, or as an activist who has led the movement for the amelioration of the wretched condition of the Dalits.

In sum, we can argue that this book has taken the discourse ahead with its unique theoretical and methodological pers-

pectives. The book tries to argue that the Dalit discourse is not related only to the production and analysis of empirical data. Rather, it has the capacity to evolve different types of theoretical and conceptual propositions and analyse the socio-political, religious, and educational phenomena occurring at the national and international level. In this way, we have tried to analyse Ambedkar's contributions in the arena of academics at par with any other Indian, European or American social scientist.

I hope this book will motivate the contemporary and upcoming generations of social scientists to go beyond their existing paradigms and evolve new paradigms so that their production of knowledge shows the path to national and international fraternity in academia.

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Introduction

Decoding Babasaheb Ambedkar: Ideas and Praxis

This chapter is the outcome of a series of ‘Annual Ambedkar Memorial’ lectures delivered by the author at the University of British Columbia, Simon Fraser University, and York University, Canada, from 2 to 15 November 2017. It highlights the process of reductionism and erasure of Ambedkar across mainstream Indian academia and intelligentsia. The author makes an attempt here to highlight; on the one hand, that Ambedkar has been reduced only to a Dalit leader, knowingly or unknowingly. On the other hand, he has been erased from literature, sociology and history textbooks. Above all, he has also been ignored in the field of creative and artistic production. However, the chapter tries to decode Ambedkar by understanding various facets of his personality, thoughts and actions. Hence, the author explores the vast storage of Ambedkar’s objective and scientific knowledge, with its multiple shades.

Further, to deconstruct the aforesaid twin processes leading to the victimization of Ambedkar, we have also tried to probe how he has been getting accepted all over the world, especially by Western and American academia, researchers and the general public as well. Above all, drawing methodological legitimacy from a number of social scientists, we have tried to evolve a perspective that is, ‘a Perspective from Below’ and explain how

personal experiences can produce reliable data that can be used to understand social reality.

There are two very important reasons why I have titled this chapter the way it is. These are: (a) The perspective of the article and second, (b) The process of reductionism and ‘erasure’ of Ambedkar and his ideas that have taken place in Indian society.

Let us first highlight some significant facts about the perspective of this chapter.

ACADEMIC LEGITIMACY AND ‘PERSPECTIVE FROM BELOW’

There can be several perspectives to understand Babasaheb Ambedkar. I have called my perspective, on the book, the *Perspective From Below* (Kumar 2018).

This is a perspective in which knowledge is produced by people who have their consciousness shaped out of their unique structural location at the lowest ebb of the Indian social order. This structural location is unique because it is due to this that they were forced to suffer from cumulative and collective exclusion. The former means that they are simultaneously excluded from social, economic, political, religious, educational, spatial, etc. spheres of life (ibid.). The term ‘collective’ here means that it is not one individual who suffers this exclusion; rather, the community as a whole suffers from exclusion. Further, their location has a bearing on the construction of consciousness, out of which the production of knowledge takes place (Kumar 2018: 57-78).

I have tried to establish this perspective on the basis of propositions laid down by various social scientists like Mills (1959), Berger and Luckmann (1967), Bourdieu (1986), Kuhn (1969), and Freire (1970). For instance, Mills (1959: 157) argues that ‘. . . problems of biography, of history and their interaction within social systems are coordinate points of the proper study

of man . . . [and] . . . an integral part of sociological imagination'. Luckmann and Berger (1967: 4) argue that 'sociology constitutes the sociological focus . . . on the existential determination of thought'. Bourdieu (1986: 16) has highlighted that ' . . . accumulation of cultural capital . . . starts only for the offspring of families embodied with strong cultural capital and takes place through hereditary transmission'.

Integrating these three propositions together, we can show how biography, that is the lived experience of Dalits suffering from a unique type of social exclusion because of their structural location and exclusion from the mainstream social and cultural capital, shapes their consciousness out of which production of knowledge takes place. This chapter considers the aforesaid proposition in shaping the perspective of the author out of which this chapter is written.

Further, thinkers like Kuhn (1969) and Freire (1970) give academic legitimacy to *Perspective From Below*. Kuhn (1969) argues that research is not only done through data collection but it can be done by changing paradigms as well. Therefore, the *Perspective From Below* changes the paradigm for analysing Ambedkar's thoughts and actions. First, it tries to understand the processes of reductionism and then deconstructs the established image of Ambedkar by providing a parallel discourse on Ambedkar's thoughts and actions. It is in this context that this paper draws from Freire (1970), who has argued that 'the pedagogy of the oppressed cannot be developed or practised by the oppressor'. According to him, it has to be developed by the oppressed himself. The oppressed, through this pedagogy, helps us to ' . . . understand the causes of oppression', and from this reflection, necessary engagement for liberation can be developed. Similarly, 'Perspective From Below' can help us to understand the erasures, reductionism and stigmatization of Babasaheb Ambedkar.

REDUCTIONISM AND ERASURE OF AMBEDKAR

Having defined the perspective used in the chapter to understand reality, let me come to the second point, the issues of reductionism and erasure of Ambedkar. What exactly do I mean by the propositions—‘reductionism’ and ‘blackout’/‘erasure’ of Ambedkar? By reductionism, I mean that

- (a) Ambedkar has been either understood only as a Dalit leader or as an intellectual who was only engaged with caste or annihilation of caste.
- (b) Many intellectuals or journalists still doubt that Ambedkar was the chief architect of the Indian constitution.
- (c) The third dimension of the process of reductionism is that the intellectuals and academia have not been able to recognize different shades of his thoughts and perspectives with which he has tried to understand the social realities of Indian and global society.
- (d) The fourth dimension of reductionism is that the media and academia have failed to recognize the various stages and dynamics of his movements.

UNDERSTANDING REDUCTIONISM

Ambedkar has been reduced merely to a Dalit leader and an intellectual who was only engaged with the annihilation of caste. The first example comes from Eleanor Zelliot’s PhD dissertation, itself, in which she analysed Ambedkar’s movement from a particular caste perspective and as a leader of the Mahar caste. Her PhD thesis ‘Dr. Ambedkar and the Mahar Movement’. Zelliot has not even engaged with him as the leader of ex-untouchable communities as a whole. She did her work on Dalits in the early 1960s and submitted her thesis in 1969 (Zelliot 2004: Preface). It is difficult to understand why she could not appreciate the larger canvas of Ambedkar’s

thought and philosophy, his role as leader of a number of movements and chief architect of the Indian constitution. Perhaps, that is why she herself wrote, ‘I was never satisfied that I had done justice to Dr Ambedkar. . . . The unfortunate title prompted the idea that Ambedkar was only a Mahar leader’ (ibid: Preface).

Arun Shourie, considered to be then one of India’s topmost journalists and went on to become a cabinet minister in Vajpayee’s government, published a book titled, *Worshipping the False God: Ambedkar, and the Facts Which Have Been Erased* to prove his point that Ambedkar was not the chief architect of the Indian constitution. He was only a *rapporteur*. In his own words,

. . . the Constitution came to be framed—by the collective, iterative deliberations of a very large number. Ambedkar was one of these members. In some ways, he played an important part. But his job was really that of a *rapporteur*, not that of one who set policy, certainly not that of the creator (Shourie 1997, 2012: 449-50).

Shourie further stigmatized Ambedkar by arguing that ‘The legacy of Ambedkar is a country with a deepened sense of shame in its entire past. And thereby disabled’ (Shourie 1997, 2012: 381). Another example of reductionism comes as late as 2014. This time, a literary personality, Arundhati Roy (2014), in her effort to popularize Ambedkar’s writings, could not see beyond Ambedkar’s *Annihilation of Caste* as his most valuable contribution. The reductionism can be further substantiated by the point that her introduction was more voluminous than Ambedkar’s text, *Annihilation of Caste*.

The worst and almost ‘blasphemous’ statement of reductionism and stigmatization of Ambedkar comes from the history book *Bharat Ka Mukti Sangram* (Indian Liberation War) by Ayodhya Singh. The book was a popular reading of its time for two reasons. One, it was published by an established and reputed publisher. Second, it ran in many editions and several reprints. For instance,

its first edition came in 1977, the second in 1992, and third in 2003. In between there were three reprints of the book in 1987, 1994, and 1996 as well. The introduction of the writer on the back page of the book says that he was a journalist, writer, and freedom fighter. He was associated with a very progressive magazine, *Saptahik Swadhintā* (Weekly Freedom), published in Calcutta. His most famous book includes *Hindustan ka Swadhintā Aandolan aur Communist* (India's Freedom Movement and Communist). Let us see what a so-called intellectual has to say about Ambedkar.

Singh writes that *Ambedkar . . . Baroda ke Raja aur Mahar jaati ki achhut kanya ke Putra the . . . Vah maldar aur jamindar Harijanon ke drishtikon ka pratinidhitv karte the Ambedkar ne jo gyapan commission (simon) ke samne pesh kiya tha vah angrej parasth tha* (Singh 2003: 459-60). Ambedkar was the son of the King of Baroda and daughter of Mahar caste . . . he used to represent the view of affluent and feudal Harijans. The memorandum which Ambedkar presented before the commission (Simon) was pro-British—Author's translation.

The moot question is how someone can write about such a famous personality, and that too as late as the 1970s when so much was already written about him and he had occupied a number of national positions and had launched a number of mass movements for the downtrodden. The worst is that he has gone unchallenged to this date.

The misunderstanding about the real identity and status of Ambedkar has always existed. Look at what Kumar (2005: 514) had to say,

Gandhiji, after discussing the problems of Dalits with Ambedkar, asked Mahadev Desai why Ambedkar told him that he (Ambedkar) did not have a motherland. Desai explained that it was because Ambedkar was an 'untouchable'. Gandhiji was surprised to learn this, and he told Desai that he had thought Ambedkar was a

conscientious Brahmin who spoke for the untouchables. . . . Even as late as 1999, a high-profile university professor of sociology, who has extensively worked on the issues related to caste, asked me, ‘What is the difference between Jai Shree Ram and Jai Bheem, as both are religious symbols?’ I had to explain to the learned professor that this Jai Bheem is not the Bheem of *Mahabharat*; it comes from the first name of Bheemrao Ambedkar, which has now become the greeting symbol of Dalits and other marginalized groups in India and across the globe.

UNDERSTANDING AMBEDKAR’S ERASURE

Provided a few examples to prove the point of how Ambedkar has been the victim of ‘reductionism’, let us take a certain examples to prove the point of his erasures. As far as the proposition erasure is concerned, I want to argue that, on the one hand, he has been erased from pioneering literary, sociological texts and texts on Indian history; on the other hand, he has also been erased from visual and artistic works. However, at this point in time, because of lack of resources, it is difficult to ascertain whether these erasures are by design or by default.

The first literary text from which Babasaheb Ambedkar has been completely erased is Mulk Raj Anand’s novel *Untouchable* (1935). In this text, Gandhiji is hailed as the emancipator of untouchables. It is a fact that by the time Anand had written his text, Ambedkar had already arrived on the horizon of the emancipation of Dalits, and he already had a steady movement for the upliftment of Dalits. However, Anand has completely ignored Ambedkar’s social, political, educational, and religious movements for ameliorating Dalits from their wretched condition.

As far as erasure from academic texts is concerned, there are several examples from this sphere. However, the first text in question is G.S. Ghurye’s *Caste and Race in India* first published in 1932.

The book was published one and a half decades after Ambedkar's *Caste in India: Their Mechanism, Genesis and Development*, published in the *Antiquary Journal*. However, Ghurye takes cognizance of Ambedkar's writings on caste only once (Ghurye 1932: 216-17). *The Case of Louis Dumont's Homo Hierarchicus*, first published in the 1970s with several publications thereafter, is different. In this book, Ambedkar's work has not been cited even once. Several other sociologists have worked on caste extensively, but have not taken note of Ambedkar's works like—*Caste in India: Their Mechanism, Genesis and Development* (Ambedkar 1979), *Annihilation of Caste* (Ambedkar 1979), *Who Were the Shudras?* (Ambedkar 1990(c)), *The Untouchables: Who Were They and Why They Became Untouchables?* (Ambedkar 1990(c)), etc. Based on the academic arguments contained in the aforesaid Ambedkar's works, it can be easily argued that any analysis of caste without these works would be incomplete.

The third example of the erasure of Ambedkar can be witnessed in the influential history text by Bipan Chandra et al. (1989). This book is running in a number of editions. I have seen its seventh edition. That means the book is widely circulated and has made an impact on people's minds. In this book, with 600 pages (including bibliography and index), Ambedkar's name appears first time on page number 291 and then on pages 293-4, 336 and 364. Out of these five times where Ambedkar's name appears, to begin with, on page 291, Ambedkar is referred in passing with reference to Gandhi's fast-unto-death. On this page, Bipan Chandra writes, 'Political leaders of different political party persuasions, including Madan Mohan Malviya, M.C. Rajah and Ambedkar, now became active'. On page 293, he again refers to Ambedkar's name with reference to Gandhi. In the words of Chandra, '... he was not hostile to Dr. Ambedkar and other Harijans who criticized and distrusted him'.

Similarly, on page 294, Chandra analyses that, 'he disagreed with Ambedkar when the latter asserted that 'the outcaste is a

byproduct of the caste system'. On page 336 he is referred to indirectly through his followers. Chandra (1989: 336) writes, 'In Bombay, the AITUC, the Communists and the followers of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar organized a strike on 7 November 1938, in seventeen out of seventy-seven textile mills against the passage of the Industrial Dispute Act'. He doesn't even acknowledge that Ambedkar had, by that time, become a force to reckon with and had established his 'Independent Labour Party' and contested elections. Last but not least, on page 364, Ambedkar is referred to in passing in the following words,

The situation soon began to take an ugly turn, with hostile demonstrations by Rajputs and Muslims during Gandhiji's prayer meetings, and Mohammad Ali Jinnah's and Ambedkar's demand that the Muslims and Depressed Classes be given separate representation.

It is astonishing to note that on all five occasions, Ambedkar's name appears in the book only as a passing reference without any independent agency. In doing so, Chandra et al. (1989) not only ignore Ambedkar's pioneering work, *Pakistan or The Partition of India*, first published in 1940, and its second edition came in 1945. The historians argue that this was the only book-length answer to the solution to the problem of Pakistan (Anderson 2012, Kumar 2012). Not only that, Chandra also ignored Ambedkar's contribution to the Constituent Assembly, his role as the Chairman of the Drafting Committee and his role in several other subcommittees of the Indian Constitution. In this way, Ambedkar's erasure from the history textbooks is glaring and has reduced him merely as a Dalit leader.

ERASURE FROM WORK OF CREATIVE FIELD

We have discussed so far how Ambedkar has been erased in academic texts let us now analyse how he has been erased even from artistic

and creative fields like feature films. Ambedkar was completely erased from Richard Attenborough's directed film, *Gandhi*, released in 1982. This movie is an epic and historical film, and is regularly shown on Indian television on the birth and death anniversaries of M.K. Gandhi or on any other occasion of national festivals.

The feature film was nominated for Academy and Oscar awards. *Gandhi* received a leading nominations in eleven categories and won the awards in eight categories, including Best Feature Film and Best Director Award. However, in this film, Ambedkar was totally erased. However, it is a fact that Gandhi picked up the removal of untouchability as one of the agendas of his movement after the 1930s because of his conflict with Ambedkar. Gandhi's tug of war with Ambedkar at the Round Table Conference in London, his fast unto death against Separate Electorates to Dalits, signing of the famous Poona Pact in September 1932, and then Gandhi and Ambedkar dialogue on *Annihilation of Caste* (Ambedkar 1979), are all highly publicized episodes of Gandhi's life which remain fresh and not easy to be obliterated from public memory. Yet, these episodes where Ambedkar would have appeared prominently have been erased completely from the film.

In this context, one may ask why one should mention Ambedkar in the autobiographical feature film on Gandhi. The erasure of Ambedkar in *Gandhi* assumes a serious proposition because when Jabbar Patel made a feature film on Ambedkar in the year 2000, *Gandhi* was present in the film very prominently. Therefore, a contestable question emerges in this context—If Ambedkar had no relevance to Gandhi, then how come Gandhi becomes relevant in a film on the life of Ambedkar? Hence, this raises serious doubts. Is there a deliberate attempt to erase Ambedkar in the film on Gandhi? Why can't he be shown in the film beside Gandhi? A corollary to that is, can Ambedkar be analysed independently on his own without any reference to Gandhi?

HOW CAN WE DECODE AMBEDKAR'S
REDUCTIONISM AND ERASURE?

If these are a few examples to prove the point that there is a general pattern of 'Reductionism' and erasure of Ambedkar, one can ask if there are a few more reasons based on which we can argue that there exist processes of reductionism and erasure of Ambedkar in Indian society. Here again, we can highlight at least five reasons based on which we can argue that Ambedkar has been a victim of processes of reductionism and erasure. These reasons are:

- (a) The way Ambedkar has been revered by his followers and supporters.
- (b) The way he was appreciated by Columbia University while receiving an honorary L.L.D. degree in the year 1952.
- (c) The way in which Western social scientists have engaged with his academic acumen and the way he has become visible at the international level.
- (d) The horizon, shades, epistemologies, and approaches with which Ambedkar has produced his knowledge.
- (e) The nature and dynamics of his movements.

Let us briefly take these facts one-by-one to prove the point. At the outset, we understand the dimensions of Ambedkar's personality, which his followers highlight and revere. His followers address him as *Vishva Vibhooti* (global icon), *Bodhisattva* (like Buddha), *Bharat Ratna* (Indian gem after the highest civilian award of the country was conferred upon him), *Samvidhan Nirmata* (framer of the constitution) 'Babasaheb Dr. B.R. Ambedkar'. That means he is revered as a spiritual leader who has achieved a higher status of *Bodhisattva* by treading the path of Buddha and practicing the same. Second, these addresses also highlight his higher civilian achievement in Indian society, where he was conferred the country's highest civilian award, *Bharat Rattan* (gem of India).

The supporters deliberately add the epithet in front of his name, Dr. to highlight his educational achievement, which he had at that point in time without any other being near to him. His followers affectionately call him 'Babasaheb'. Apart from this, he is also revered as the maker of the Indian constitution (*Bharat ke Samvidhan Nirmata*). Last, but not least, he is also being addressed as 'Global Icon' (Vishva Vibhuti). This is the repertoire of his aura highlighted by his followers, which count in millions, yet he is reduced only to a Dalit leader by the mainstream media, academia, or intelligentsia. That is why they feel that he is not given the respect that is due to him.

REFLECTIONS BY EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTION

If this is the informal way in which Ambedkar is revered by his followers, let us observe how he is referred to by an educational formal institution. For instance, how did the Columbia University refer him while awarding an honorary degree some fifty-nine years back on 5 June 1952. The citation letter described him in the following words:

Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar LL.D. . . . for three years a graduate student in this university, receiving the doctorate in Political Science; subsequently a student of the Inns of Court and the University of London, obtaining a doctorate in economics; for the past three decades a barrister, university professor . . . as a framer of the constitution . . . one of India's leading citizens . . . a great social reformer and a valiant upholder of human rights. (L.L.D. Citation, Columbia University, see Annexure I on page 129).

In the same vein, we should also take into account how a few Western social scientists have highlighted Ambedkar's achievements in the sphere of higher education in comparison to other leaders of that time. Let us see these lines:

Gandhi did not claim much book learning . . . Nehru, on the other hand, had enjoyed higher education Gandhi lacked . . . it would be unfair to compare Nehru to Ambedkar, intellectually head and shoulder above most of the Congress leaders, in part due to far more serious training . . . at LSE and Columbia, to read who is to enter a different world (Anderson 2012: 51-2).

Another significant appreciation by a foreign dignitary came from Edwina Mountbatten, wife of the last Viceroy of India Lord Mountbatten, when she wrote a congratulatory letter to Ambedkar on his appointment as the chairman of the drafting committee of the Indian Constitution. Edwina argued, 'I am personally glad to see you supervising the Constitution'. She was so much impressed with Ambedkar that she emphasised, ' . . . you are the only genius who can give equal justice to every caste and creed' (see Annexure II on page 130). Last but not least, believing in Ambedkar's brilliance and patriotism, she accentuated, 'I have been your long time admirer and hoping you will fulfill your duty towards the country' (ibid.).

AMBEDKAR AND ENGAGEMENT OF WESTERN SCHOLARS

Apart from taking cognizance of his academic credentials, Anderson also took note of his political foresight during India's struggle for independence. According to Anderson, when Gandhi, Nehru, the whole Congress and even the Muslim League did not have a clue about the outcome of India's struggle for independence, Ambedkar alone had a solution to the Hindu-Muslim conflict. Anderson (2012: 89) argues that:

Only outside Congress was there lucidity. Predictably, of those who would go on to construct the Indian state, Ambedkar alone was early on clear-sighted enough to see that self-determination could not be denied Muslims if they wanted it, and to propose a rational solution for it. In 1944, at a time when the very idea of it was taboo in Congress, and still little more than a vague slogan in the Muslim League itself, he published the only serious work on the issue that would determine the outcome of the struggle

for independence. *Pakistan or Partition of India*, whose references range from Renan to Acton to Carson, from Canada to Ireland to Switzerland, stands as a devastating indictment of the intellectual poverty of Congress and its leaders. Critical to the Muslim introversion, alert to Savarkar's Hindutva, contemptuous of the myth of pan-religious amity, Ambedkar did not advocate separation of the two communities, but he proposed referenda to determine popular wishes and in the event that Muslims insisted on it, sketch the boundaries he thought might ensue. After partition, he would call for a division of Kashmir to allow its Muslim-majority zone, including the valley to join Pakistan.

In the same vein, Cosimo Zene (ed. 2013) has tried to compare the political philosophies of Antonio Gramsci and Ambedkar. The volume, which includes contributions of at least fourteen social scientists belonging to various parts of the world, is testimony to the fact that Ambedkar's larger ideas are being recognized and compared with other philosophers of the world. The book has an interdisciplinary approach. If Ambedkar is the owner of such high academic, social, political and educational credentials, according to Western scholars, then the mainstream media, intelligentsia, and academia in India have not been able to recognize his greatness and have reduced him to the status of a Dalit leader only. Have they willfully erased him, or is it by default? Hence, this book, on the one hand, attempts to deconstruct the established image of Ambedkar and, on the other, records his real contributions in the field of knowledge production. Further, it maps his accomplishments through different shades of movements launched by him at different intervals.

AMBEDKAR'S VISIBILITY AT THE INTERNATIONAL LEVEL

It is surprising Ambedkar's visibility has grown at the international level. This is evident from his bust being installed at Columbia

University; London School of Economics, London; Simon Fraser University; York University; Brandeis University, Boston; Massachusetts Amherst, USA; Melbourne University and Western Sydney University, Australia; Koyasan University, Japan and a Ambedkar's statue at the Buddhist Research Institute, Vietnam. The visibility has been further highlighted by the institution of lecture series and memorial lectures in his name at various universities of the world: Manchester Metropolitan University, UK; Calgary University; University of British Columbia; Simon Fraser University; and York University in Canada; and Columbia University, New York, USA (data collected during fieldwork). Last but not least, the Ambedkar Chair in Indian Constitutional Law has been established at Columbia University, USA.

Apart from his visibility at the international level through educational institutions, the social celebrations and establishment of international organizations in the Dalit diaspora all over the world have reinforced his visibility at the international level (Kumar 2013). The Dalit diaspora has forced the international community to recognize his larger contributions to the emancipation of the downtrodden and championing of their human rights. On the basis of the above empirical evidence, one is forced to say that Ambedkar has gradually transcended national boundaries to occupy the status of a global icon.

DIFFERENT SHADES OF THOUGHTS OF AMBEDKAR

It is in this context that we would also like to highlight Ambedkar's various shades of thoughts present in his writings and speeches. This will help us to decode Ambedkar's larger ideas. Methodologically, we could evolve a scope of knowledge with which he was engaged during his lifetime. We can observe at least ten shades of thoughts in his writings and speeches published during his lifetime and posthumously. These are social (Ambedkar 1979,

1987(c)(b)), political (Ambedkar 1990(c), 1991(a)), economic (Ambedkar 1989), religious (1987(a), 1992), gender (Ambedkar 1987(c)(e)), educational (Ambedkar 1982), legal and constitutional (Ambedkar 1994), developmental (Ambedkar 1987(c), 1991(a)), on human rights (1979) specific to the marginalized. This is only a suggestive list, and one can find a number of other shades of thought in his writings and speeches published by the Maharashtra government posthumously.

EPISTEMOLOGY OF AMBEDKAR'S THOUGHT

Ambedkar did not produce knowledge on a speculative basis; rather, he produced empirical knowledge. His empirical knowledge has three main foundations. The first source is the influence of Buddha, Kabir, and Phule. The second basis is his personal experiences from childhood exclusion, experience of freedom, equality and enlightened background of foreign universities to experiences as members of various kinds of public offices. It is important to emphasize that personal experiences have a significant impact on the production of knowledge and can be treated as social scientific data (Mills 1959, Luckman and Berger 1967, Freire 1970). Particularly it is noteworthy to emphasize what Mills (1959) has to say about the significance of biography as far as sociological imagination is concerned, out of which the production of knowledge takes place.

According to Mills, he is not merely concerned with external biography, which is associated with a sequence of social roles; rather, he is interested in understanding biography with reference to the institutions in which an individual plays a role. According to him, 'Such a view requires us to understand the most internal and psychological features of man: in particular his self-image and his conscience and indeed the very growth of mind' (Mills 1959: 179). Therefore, personal influences and experiences

become a source and foundation of knowledge and basically an authentic source of knowledge.

A third source of foundation of Ambedkar's knowledge depends on empirical sources. These are at least eight types of sources of data. These included archaeological sources, Indological sources, government reports and other documents, reports of commissions and committees, newspaper clippings, books and journals, personal observation and people's perception, and discussions with members of the society. Again, there are a number of permutations and combinations of these sources in the production of knowledge by Ambedkar (collated from *Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar Writings and Speeches*, specifically from vol. 1 to 13).

PERSPECTIVE AND APPROACHES TO KNOWLEDGE

Apart from different shades of thoughts and epistemology of knowledge, we can observe that Ambedkar had adopted multiple approaches to producing his knowledge. We can observe at least four approaches in his writings. These are civilizational (Ambedkar 1987(c)), historical (Ambedkar 1979, 1990(b)), evolutionary (Ambedkar 1990(b) 1992) and comparative approaches (Ambedkar 1979, 1989(c)) for the production of knowledge. To take one example to prove the point, for instance, while understanding religion in India, he began by tracing the origin of different civilizations. He then differentiated between religion and theology. He also used Müller, Durkheim, Weber, etc., to understand the meaning of religion in tribal society and modern societies.

Having discussed the perspective of the book in this chapter, the process of reductionism and the erasure of Ambedkar's larger ideas, thoughts and philosophy, we have analysed four added facts on the basis of which we can argue that there exists a process

of reductionism and erasure, of him. These are denials of taking cognizance of the ways he has been revered by his followers, how institutions have appreciated his personality and deeds, how various social scientists have understood his contributions. Last, but not least, they have not taken note of the different shades, epistemology, and perspectives with which Ambedkar has produced his knowledge. Instead of engaging with such a vast canvas of his methodologically produced objective and scientific knowledge, the Indian origin social scientists have reduced him to an individual who has written only on caste or to only a leader of Dalits.

DIFFERENT STAGES AND PHASES OF BABASAHEB'S MOVEMENTS

AMBEDKAR: THE SOCIAL REFORMER

There is a tendency among scholars and laymen alike to reduce Ambedkar's movement as an undifferentiated monolithic whole. However, if we analyse his activities a little bit closely, we can easily divide Babasaheb's movement into five different yet interrelated stages/phases. These phases were complementary and supplementary to his efforts for achieving equality, liberty, fraternity, and justice not only for the Dalits but for other social groups in general, and Indian society, in particular (see Kumar 2002). Each phase enriched his experience in fighting against the existing inequalities of the Hindu social order. The periodization of his leadership is also necessary to understand the rational of his changing socio-political stances in his long struggle.

The first phase began in early 1919 when he gave a memorandum to the franchise commission asking for self-representation of Dalits, and this continued till 1930s. During this period, he acted more like a social reformer while fighting against the rigid caste system and its draconian practice of untouchability. He was convinced by the knowledge of world

history that 'history bears out the proposition that political revolutions have always been preceded by social and religious revolutions', which is why he launched various types of social movements.

To begin with, Ambedkar formed a society, the *Bahishkrit Hitkarini Sabha* (Organization for the Interest of the Excluded), to serve the interests of outcastes on 20 July 1924, which could place their social and political problems before the government. Second, in this phase, he launched *Mahad Satyagraha* (Mahad is a place in Maharashtra and Satyagraha means peaceful sit in movement) to take water from a public tank. Another unique event that took place during the *Mahad Satyagraha* was the burning of the *Manusmriti* (sacred text by Manu who codified the social laws of the society), the sacred law book of the Hindus. Justifying his action of burning the *Manusmriti*, Ambedkar said in the 3 February 1928 issue of his *Bahishkrit Bharat* that his reading of the *Manusmriti* 'had convinced him that it was abusive and insulting in its treatment of the Shudras and it did not even remotely support the idea of social equality. To burn a thing was to register protest against the idea it represented.' In the same vein, in this phase, Ambedkar organized the *largest and longest satyagraha* on 2 March 1930 at Nasik for the Dalits' entry to the Kala Rama Temple (in this temple, the statue of Rama is black in colour). Around 15,00 Mahars and Chambhars had assembled at Nasik. But the temple had to be closed for about a year to keep them away from entering it. The *Parvati Satyagraha* in Poona also met the same fate.

Although Ambedkar was leading a movement for temple entry, he never wanted to enter them in the real sense of the term. In his own words,

I did not launch the temple entry movement because I wanted the Depressed Classes to become worshippers of idols that they were prevented from worshipping or because I believed that temple

entry would make them equal members in and an integral part of Hindu society. So far as this aspect of the case is concerned, I would advise the Depressed Classes to insist upon a complete overhauling of Hindu society and Hindu theology before they consent to become an integral part of Hindu society. I started temple entry Satyagraha only because I felt that was the best way of energizing the Depressed Classes and making them conscious of their position. As I believe I have achieved that, therefore, I have no more use for temple entry. I want the Depressed Classes to concentrate their energy and resources on politics and education (Zelliot 1992: 131).

AMBEDKAR: THE POLITICAL LEADER

The second phase started in 1930 and ended with his joining the Constituent Assembly. During this period, he acted more like a political leader, emphasizing the need to establish the fundamental rights of the Dalits, acquire their political rights and establish a few political parties to realize these political rights. For instance, defining the interests and rights of the Dalits, Ambedkar opined,

The untouchables are usually regarded as objects of pity but they are ignored in any political scheme on the score that they have no interest to protect. And yet their interests are the greatest. Not that they have large property to protect from confiscation. But they have their very persona confiscated (Ambedkar 1979: 255).

The socio-religious disabilities have dehumanized the untouchables, and their interests at stake are, therefore the interests of humanity. The interests of property are nothing before such primary interests. . . . The untouchable is not even a citizen. Citizenship is a bundle of rights such as: (1) personal liberty, (2) personal security, (3) right to hold private property, (4) equality before the law, (5) liberty of conscience, (6) freedom of opinion and speech,

(7) right to assembly, (8) right of representation in a country's government and (9) right to hold office under the State . . . These are the interests of the untouchables (Ambedkar 1979: 255-6).

Second, during this phase, he also went on to participate in the Round Table Conference in London and won the 'Separate Electorate' for the Dalits. The latter gave Dalits the power of two votes. Through one vote, they would elect their own caste representatives, and in another one, they could elect the general caste representative. This was unique because it gave them their true representative. However, Gandhi, as the representative of the Indian National Congress, did not accept the separate electorate for the Dalits and went on to fast unto death. This led Ambedkar to enter into a pact called the 'Poona Pact' in September 1932. Responding to the fast unto death of Gandhi, Ambedkar issued a press statement on Gandhi's fast to expose his tactics, 'suffice it is to say that although Mr Gandhi declared a fast unto death, he did not want to die. He wanted very much to live' (Ambedkar 1991(a): 88).

Further, Ambedkar argued that the fast created a problem of how to save Gandhi's life. All eyes turned on Ambedkar for the same. To this, Ambedkar reflected,

As to myself it is no exaggeration to say that no man was placed in a greater and graver dilemma than I was then. It was a baffling situation. I had to make a choice between two different alternatives. There was before me the duty, which I owed as a part of common humanity, to save Gandhi from sure death. There was before me the problem of saving for the untouchables the political rights, which the Prime Minister had given them. I responded to the call of humanity and saved the life of Mr Gandhi by agreeing to alter the Communal Award in manner satisfactory to Mr Gandhi (Ambedkar 1991(a): 88).

After the Poona Pact, separate electorates were converted to 'Joint Electorates', which exists even today. Despite this

fact, Ambedkar had an impact on independent political rights for the Dalits because of which they could represent themselves in politics. With this achievement, Ambedkar formed the Independent Labour Party in 1936, contested the Bombay Assembly elections and won several seats. The elections gave him and Dalits new confidence, and in 1942, he launched the All India Scheduled Caste Federation to broaden his national political base. During this phase, he had a discussion and later exchanged words with Ram Manohar Lohia to launch a united political party (Lohia 1964: 31-2). However, Ambedkar could not do so because of his untimely death on 6 December 1956. But he was quite successful in laying the foundation of the Republican Party of India, which was formed in 1957 after his *mahaparinirvana* (death in Pali language).

In his political party, Ambedkar also established a women's wing and used to have regular and simultaneous sessions along with the main political party and used to address women cadres. He groomed many women leaders in his party who later on went on to become Members of the Legislative Assembly. Such was Ambedkar's politics. He never mixed religion with politics, and tried to mobilize people in politics on a secular basis.

THE CHIEF ARCHITECT OF THE INDIAN CONSTITUTION

The third phase of Ambedkar's movement started in 1946 when he entered the Constituent Assembly and became the chairman of the Drafting Committee. Ambedkar's entrance into the Constituent Assembly, even against his will, is regarded as the third phase of his leadership in the sphere of Dalit amelioration. As the chairman of the Drafting Committee, Ambedkar bore the burden of not only drafting the various democratic principles but also of defending them clause by clause in the Constituent Assembly debates. The Constituent Assembly worked for two

years, eleven months and seventeen days since it first met on 9 December 1946. That means Ambedkar had to be present on all these days. Further, in this regard, one can make out the amount of labour and time he had to put into preparing the constitution by his following reflection.

Ambedkar argued that the draft constitution, as prepared by the constitutional adviser, was a text for the Drafting Committee to work upon, consisting of 243 Articles and thirteen Schedules. In its final form, the draft constitution contained 395 Articles and eight Schedules. The total number of amendments to the draft constitution tabled was approximately 7,635. Of them, the total number of amendments actually moved in the house was over 2,473 (Ambedkar 1994: 1206). That means he read all the 7,635 amendments, discarded 5,162 amendments and incorporated 2,473 amendments to produce our constitution, a herculean task with extraordinary intellect (ibid.).

The members of the Constituent Assembly have accepted the amount of labour, both intellectual and physical, that was put in by Ambedkar in the preparation of the final shape of the Constitution of India. For instance, praising Ambedkar's contribution, T.T. Krishnamachari, one of the senior members of the Constituent Assembly from the then Madras Presidency, opined in the assembly that,

Mr President Sir, I am one of those in the house who have listened to Dr. Ambedkar very carefully. I am aware of the amount of work and enthusiasm that he has brought to bear on the work of drafting this constitution. . . . The house is perhaps aware that of the seven members nominated by you, one had resigned from the house and was replaced. One died and was not replaced. One was in America and his place was not filled up and another person was engaged in state affairs and there was a void to that extent. One or two people were away from Delhi and perhaps reasons of health did not permit them to attend. So, it ultimately happened that the burden

of drafting this Constitution fell on Dr. Ambedkar and I have no doubt that we are grateful to him for having achieved this task in a manner that is undoubtedly commendable (Ambedkar 1994: 72).

This is the contribution of Ambedkar in the making of the Indian constitution and yet people are not ready to accept his contributions.

Further, during the third epoch, he also joined the Nehru cabinet and became the first law minister of independent India but resigned in October 1951. In his capacity as law minister of the country, Babasaheb wanted to bring into law what he had titled the 'Hindu Code Bill' to empower Hindu women as a whole. The bill was envisaged to secure a dignified and equal status for Hindu women with a number of clauses. There were rights of inheritance and maintenance. There were laws against dowry. Instead of polygamy, monogamy was made legal. The Hindu marriage became a contract instead of a sacrament. The consent of the wife was to be made compulsory in the event of adoption. He had also mooted that, like son, wife and daughter should be given a share in the property of husband and father, respectively. Ambedkar, in his proposed Hindu Code Bill, attempted to 'consolidate the different categories of *stridhan* into a single category of property and lay down the uniform rule of succession' (Ambedkar 1995: 7). We will further elaborate on this fact in Chapter 4 of this book.

AMBEDKAR: THE RELIGIOUS RENOUNCER

In the fourth phase of his leadership (1952-6), Babasaheb emerged as a renouncer and religious leader. He started mobilizing his supporters to embrace Buddhism and finally returned to its fold on 14 October 1956 before attaining *nirvana* on 6 December 1956. Ambedkar's conversion to

Buddhism has been criticized as a political act. Again, it is a case of the reductionism of his larger vision. Zelliott has replied very aptly to such critics. She argued,

‘What possible political advantage does conversion offer?’ Conversion to Buddhism immediately cuts off . . . deserving governmental benefits . . . to Untouchable castes. Ambedkar’s delayed conversion came long after the period of combining the conversion idea with political expediency, and by then reference to the conversion as a political threat had lost its significance. Instead, it had reference to the great Asian Buddhist world, the reputation of Buddhism as an important religion both in India and the West and the possibility of Buddhism as a moral force (Zelliott 1992: 195).

We are aware of the fact that Babasaheb was well aware of the ‘Sciences of Religion’ and had a deep understanding of different religions of the world. He had meaningfully engaged and interpreted scholars like Müller, Weber, and Durkheim on religion. That is why he could differentiate between theology and rituals as two parts of the religion. However, he was convinced about the necessity of religion in the society. According to him, religion is the most significant institution which performs the most significant role of social control. The law cannot have full control in the society. That is why he argued that religion is very essential for the Dalits as well. However, according to him, religion should be egalitarian in nature.

That is why when he got the opportunity, he chose Buddhism because he was of the opinion that it was based on egalitarian principles like equality, liberty, and fraternity (Ambedkar 2003: 503). Second, there is no mediator between God and people. People can be their own guides. There is no church and no idea of soul and rebirth (Ambedkar 1992: 250-59). Hence, Buddha’s gospel would be the most effective ideology of emancipation for the Dalits who need psychological and social uplift; that is

why instead of Hinduism, Ambedkar chose Buddhism as the religion for the emancipation of Dalits.

Ambedkar, after conversion, was called to participate at the World Buddhist Conference from 15-16 November 1956. Ambedkar's last effort was to popularize the Buddhist faith in India. Therefore, he wrote a full-length book *Buddha and His Dhamma*. He tried to explain the tenets of Buddhism in this book in the most simple language for the common masses and tried to eliminate the confusion created by Brahmanical interpretation, which had intruded into Buddha's life. In the Introduction of this book, Ambedkar has argued that he has given '... a clear and consistent statement of the life and teachings of the Buddha' (Ambedkar 1992).

AMBEDKAR THE EDUCATOR

Apart from these four shades, there is a fifth shade of his movement, which cuts across all four stages/phases of his movements and is the phase in which he acts as an educator. Who can forget Ambedkar's famous slogan, 'Educate, Agitate and Organize' (Ambedkar 2003: 276), which he gave in 'The All-India Depressed Classes' conference held at Nagpur from 18-20 July 1942. He reiterated the same slogan in 1945 at the annual conference as 'The All India Scheduled Castes Federation' (Ambedkar 1979: 357). This slogan has been accepted by the Dalit masses as a guiding principle to motivate them to take education as a tool of their emancipation.

During this period, he brought out at least five newspapers to educate his people regarding the tyrannies and oppression to which Dalits were subjected. The first newspapers were *Mook Nayak* (Hero of the Voiceless), started in 1920, *Bahishkrit Bharat* (Ex-communicated Indians) started in 1927 till 1929, *Samata* (Equality) started in 1928, *Janata* (The People) started in 1930,

and last but not the least *Prabuddha Bharat* (The Enlightened Indian) started in February 1956. Through these newspapers, he wanted to awaken the downtrodden masses from their age-old lethargy and inaction and unite them.

Ambedkar also helped and motivated regional wings of his political parties to publish newspapers. For instance, in 1945, the Bengal Provincial Scheduled Caste Federation, associated with a national political party, the All India Scheduled Caste Federation, started the *People's Herald* newspaper from Calcutta. Speaking on the inaugural function of the newspaper, Ambedkar emphasized, 'A newspaper is . . . one means of educating people' (Ambedkar 2003: 348).

As far as formal education is concerned, he asked the government to grant concessions, scholarships and other facilities to Dalit students. During this phase, he founded the People's Education Society in Bombay in 1945. In 1946, he established the Siddharth College of Arts and Science to provide basic and non-discriminatory scientific education to Dalits and others.

CONCLUSION

On the basis of the above discussion, we can conclude that the mainstream academia, intelligentsia, and media have been, knowingly or unknowingly, involved in the process of reductionism, erasure, and stigmatization of Ambedkar, among his followers across the globe. These triple processes are evident in the above discussions, which have been substantiated on the basis of empirical data. We have observed them in the history, sociology, literary texts, and books produced by journalists. Even in the creative fields like film, the erasure of Ambedkar is so glaring. Not only that, there prevails a lot of misunderstandings around his real identity.

However, we have observed that these processes can be

deconstructed with the help of empirical data collected with a perspective called consistency 'the Perspective from Below'. The data from this perspective has been collected both from India and across the world. The data portrays Ambedkar in a very different light and proves the point that his acceptance at the international level is growing day by day. If we engage with this data, we have observed that it created a totally new discourse. This discourse portrays Ambedkar as an academician who has engaged with social realities concerning our nation and the globe. That is why the social scientists of the world are engaging with him, and the institutions are having his busts along with his books. That is why it is pertinent to decode the vast ocean of his knowledge.

NOTE

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Caste and Annihilation of Caste

INTRODUCTION

In this chapter, we have discussed Ambedkar's views on *varna* and individual's place in *varna*, the origin of caste and the question of annihilation of caste. Ambedkar has engaged with the structure of Indian society in great detail. He has emphasized that this structure is based on the 'individual' and his place in *varna*. Theoretically, this is a very significant sociological proposition that has not been highlighted by various social scientists and sociologists. Ambedkar is of the opinion that the Hindu social order does not recognize the existence of individuals that are part of a larger group called *varna* (a division of the society into four classes—Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas and Shudras). The *varna* is a hierarchically arranged system with unequal rights and privileges. Because of this hierarchical arrangement of *varnas*, with unequal rights and privileges, the Hindu social order lacks the principles of equality, liberty and fraternity and, hence, democracy.

Apart from *varna*, this chapter also discusses Ambedkar's theory of genesis, mechanism and development of caste. We have probed how he has refuted the theories of the origin of caste as propounded by various European social thinkers and then how he has propounded his own thesis regarding the origin of caste in Indian society. Further, in this context, we have also discussed the mechanism through which the caste has developed and spread in every nook and corner of the Indian society. Last, but not the least, Ambedkar has not only given the structure of *varna* and the mechanism of caste, but has also propounded his thesis and the scheme to annihilate the caste system.

In doing so, Ambedkar challenged the social reforms practiced by different socio-political forces of his time. Ambedkar analysed the nature and quality of social reforms as proposed by the then Congress, Socialists, and Arya Samajis (an organization of Hindus who believed in the Vedas in its pristine and pure state). He outrightly rejected them all because, in his opinion, they all could not understand the problem, but gave very shallow remedies to annihilate the caste system. Against the lopsided and petty reforms suggested by other forces, Ambedkar propounded philosophically and theoretically very radical reforms in the Hindu social order for the annihilation of caste.

To begin with, he argued that if one has to annihilate caste, then

I am convinced that the real remedy is inter-marriage. Fusion of blood can alone create the feelings of being kith and kin, and unless this feeling of being kindred, becomes paramount the separatist feeling—the feeling of being aliens—created by caste will not vanish. . . . The real remedy for breaking caste is inter-marriage. Nothing else will serve as the solvent of caste (Ambedkar 1979: 67).

The second proposition of annihilation of caste as proposed by Ambedkar is,

The real remedy is to destroy the belief in the sanctity of *Shashtra*. . . . You must, therefore, destroy the sacredness and divinity with which caste has become invested . . . this means you must destroy the authority of the *Shastras* and Vedas (sacred texts of Hindus) (Ambedkar 1979: 68-9).

The third method to annihilate caste was the abolition of priesthood by one caste (ibid.); rather, he suggested that priests should be servants of the state. Further, I draw an inference from Ambedkar's argument, which is not latently related to the annihilation of caste; that is, he opined that,

. . . the priesthood must at least cease to be hereditary. Every person who professes to be Hindu must be eligible for being a priest. It should be provided by law . . . and holds a *Sanad* from the state. . . . (Ambedkar 1979: 77).

In this way, this chapter will present a comprehensive picture of the caste system as envisaged and analysed by Ambedkar. We have observed that, usually, social scientists analyse caste as an independent unit. However, according to Ambedkar, if we have to understand caste, then we have to understand Hindu social structure as well. Hindu social structure comprises *varna* in a hierarchical order. He treats *varna* as class. Moreover, *varnas* are further divided into castes because of the imposition of exogamy over endogamy. He refutes the occupational, racial, and communal theory of the genesis of caste. Last but not the least, he gives his proposition of annihilation of caste.

AMBEDKAR'S PERSPECTIVE ON CASTE

Ambedkar drew attention to the rigidity of the caste system and its essential features. Graded inequality is the fundamental principle on which caste is based. That is beyond doubt, Ambedkar emphasized. According to him,

The four classes are not only different but also unequal in status; one stands above the other. In the scheme of Manu, the Brahmin occupies the uppermost rank, followed by the Kshatriya, Vaishya, and Shudra. Below the Shudra is *ati-Shudra*, or the untouchable. This order of precedence among the classes is not merely conventional. It is spiritual, moral and legal. There is no sphere of life that is not regulated by this principle of graded inequality (Ambedkar 1987(c): 107).

Further, Ambedkar has also highlighted the fact that, 'The principle of graded inequality has been carried into the economic field' (ibid.: 111). The Hindu social order does not

recognize, 'From each according to his ability; to each according to his needs'. It favours the distribution of the good things of life among those who are reckoned as the highest in the social hierarchy.

The second principle on which the Hindu social order is founded is that of prescribed graded occupations that are inherited from father to son for each class. In other words, it can be termed as 'fixity of occupations for each class and continuance by heredity' (ibid.). The third feature of the Hindu social order, according to Ambedkar, is the confinement of interaction of people to their respective groups instead of inter-dining and inter-marriages, between people of different classes. According to Ambedkar, there is nothing strange or peculiar that the Hindu social order recognizes classes. There are classes everywhere, and no society exists without them; even a free social order will not be able to get rid of the classes completely. A free social order, however, aims to prevent isolation and exclusiveness because it prevents the members of the class from becoming inimical towards one another (Ambedkar 1987(c): 113).

(a) INTERPRETATION OF VARNA THEORY

Ambedkar recognized the existence of four *varnas* in the Hindu social order. He emphasized that the Hindu social order is primarily based on the class (*varna*) and not on individuals. He opined that the unit of Hindu society is neither the individual Brahmin, nor the individual Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra, or the Untouchables. Even the family is not regarded, in the Hindu social order, as a unit of society except for the purposes of marriage and inheritance. The unit of Hindu society is the class (*varna*). In the Hindu social order, there is no room for individual merit and no consideration of individual justice. If a person has a privilege, it is not because it is due to him/her as an individual.

The privilege goes with the class, and if he/she is found to enjoy it, it is because he/she belongs to that class. Conversely, an individual suffers not because he/she deserves it by virtue of his/her conduct; rather, it is because he/she belongs to that class. Ambedkar analysed the impact of the division of society into *varnas* in the Hindu social order. He argued that because of this division, the Hindu social order has failed to uphold the values of liberty, equality and fraternity—the three essentials of a free social order. The Hindus do believe that God created different classes of people from different parts of his divine body. According to Ambedkar (1987(c): 100)

The doctrine that the different classes were created from different parts of the divine body has generated the belief that it must be divine will that they should remain separate and distinct. It is this belief that has created in the Hindu an instinct to be different, to be separate and to be distinct from the rest of his fellow Hindus.

In the same vein, Ambedkar adds that

The most extensive and wild manifestation of this spirit of isolation and separation is of course the caste-system. . . . Originally, there were four only. Today, how many are there? It is estimated that the total is not less than 2,000. It must be 3,000. . . . Castes are divided into sub-castes (Ambedkar, 1987(c): 102).

The question that Ambedkar raised is, ‘What fraternity can there be in a social order based upon such sentiments?’ Ambedkar asks, ‘Does the Hindu social order recognize equality?’ He underlines that while the Hindu social order accepts that men have come from the body of the creator of the universe, it does not treat them as equal because they were created from the different parts of his body that are themselves graded in terms of perceived importance and locations. The Brahmins were created from the mouth, the Kshatriyas from the arms, the Vaishyas from

his thighs and the Shudras from the feet. Ambedkar agrees with natural endowments, as he opined that the Hindu social order, refuses to recognize that men no matter how profoundly they differ as individuals in capacity and character, are equally entitled as human beings to consideration and respect, and that the well-being of a society is likely to be increased if it plans its organization that, whether their powers are great or small, all its members may be equally enabled to make the best of such powers as they possess (Ambedkar 1987(c): 106).

It is for this reason he feels that the Hindu social order is against the 'equalitarian temper', and does not allow equality of circumstances, institutions and lifestyles to develop. In the same context, Ambedkar upholds that there is an absence of liberty, specifically 'liberty of action', in the Hindu social order because the occupation and status of the individuals are all fixed on the basis of their birth in a particular family. The same is true for political liberty as well. The Hindu social order does not recognize the necessity of a representative government chosen by the people. According to him, though the Hindu social order does recognize that laws must govern the people, it negates the idea that the laws can be made by the representatives chosen by the people. Ambedkar submits that the Hindus are of the opinion that the laws by which people are to be governed already exist in the Vedas, and no human being is empowered to bring about a change in the existing laws (Ambedkar 1987(c): 114). In the absence of equality and liberty, there is no fraternity in the Hindu social order. In this context, Ambedkar asks the question, 'Does the Hindu social order recognize fraternity?' and then goes on to demonstrate that fraternity does not exist in the Hindu society.

To demonstrate the aforementioned fact, Ambedkar took a survey of Hindu social structure and its philosophy. According to him,

The Hindus . . . do believe that men are created by God . . . But . . . God created different men from different parts of his divine body . . . and therefore. . . The Brahmin is no brother of the Kshatriya because the former is born from the mouth of the divinity while the latter is from the arms. The Kshatriya is no brother of the Vaishya because the former is born from the arms and the latter from the thighs. As no one is a brother to the other, no one is the keeper of the other' (Ambedkar 1987(c): 100).

Further, Ambedkar substantiated his argument 'why there is no fraternity among Hindus' by arguing that

. . . the doctrine that the classes (*varnas*) were created from different parts of the Divine body has generated the belief that it must be divine will that they should remain separate and distinct. It is this belief that has created in Hindus an instinct to be different, to be separated and to be distinct from the rest of his fellow Hindus. . . It is also the Hindu instinct due to the same belief never to overlook a difference if it does exist but to emphasize it, recognize it, and to blaze it forth (Ambedkar 1987(c): 100-101).

The caste system is the best example of such instinct, which emphasizes, recognizes and blazes the difference between different castes. According to Ambedkar,

The most extensive and wild manifestation of this spirit of isolation and separation is, of course, the caste-system. . . Originally there were four castes only. Today . . . It might be 3000. This is not the only staggering aspect of this fact. There are others. Castes are divided into sub-castes . . . (For e.g.) . . . The total population of the Brahmin Caste is about a *crore* and a half. But there are 1886 sub-castes . . . there are 1886 sub-castes of Brahmin caste!! In Punjab alone, the Saraswat Brahmins are divided into 469 sub-castes. The Kayastha's of Punjab are divided into 890 sub-castes' (Ambedkar 1987(c): 100-102).

If the Hindu society is so-deeply fragmented on the lines of *varna*, castes and sub-castes, then what is the social impact on the groups and individuals who constitute it? On this, Ambedkar argues that the impact is,

... infinite process of splitting social life into small fragments. The splitting process has made a social life quite impossible. . . . Their guiding principle is 'be separate', 'do not inter-marry, do not inter-dine' and 'do not touch' . . . Far from working in a spirit of fraternity the mutual relations of the castes are fratricidal . . . (for instance) . . . there has been . . . a class war between Brahmans and Kshatriyas that lasted for several generations and which was fought so hard and with such virulence that it turned out to be a war of extermination. It must not be supposed that the fratricidal spirit has given place to a spirit of fraternity. The same spirit of separation marks the Hindu Social order today. This is best illustrated by the rules of hyper commensality and the rules of hypergamy . . . (which are) spirit of high and low (Ibid.).

Hence, he concluded that 'The Hindu Social order is a ladder of castes placed one above the other together are representing the ascending scale of hatred and the descending scale of contempt' (ibid.: 105). Therefore, one can easily argue that the Hindu Social order lacks fraternity.

(b) GENESIS OF CASTE SYSTEM

After defining the Hindu social order comprising *varna* in a hierarchical pattern, Ambedkar proposed his theory of the origin of caste as well. To propound his own theory of the genesis of the caste system in India, Ambedkar first analysed the definitions of caste as proposed in India by Senart, Nesfield, Risley, and Ketkar closely. According to Senart, Ambedkar opined that

a caste is a close corporation, in theory at any rate rigorously hereditary; equipped with a certain traditional and independent organization, including a chief and a council meeting on occasion in assemblies of more or less plenary authority and joining together at certain festivals: bound together by common occupation, which relate more particularly to marriage and food and to questions of ceremonial pollution, and ruling its members by the exercise of jurisdiction, the extent of which varies, but which succeeds in making the authority of the community more felt by the sanction of certain penalties and above all by final irrevocable exclusion from the group' (Ambedkar 1979: 6-7).

Further, Ambedkar also highlights that Nesfield has defined a caste as 'a class of the community that disowns any connection with any other class and can neither intermarry nor eat nor drink with any but a person of their own community' (ibid.: 7) Ambedkar quotes Risley, according to whom,

a caste may be defined as a collection of families or groups of families bearing a common name that usually denotes or is associated with a specific occupation, claiming common descent from a mythical ancestor, human or divine, professing to follow the same professional callings and being regarded by those who are competent to give an opinion as forming a single homogeneous community.

Finally, Ambedkar takes note of Ketkar's definition of caste. According to Ketkar caste is,

a social group having two characteristics: (I) membership is confined to those who are born of members and includes all persons so born; (II) the members are forbidden by an inexorable social law to marry outside the group (ibid.).

Reviewing the aforementioned definitions of castes given by different social scientists, Ambedkar emphasized that most scholars have defined caste as an isolated unit, which is not correct,

according to Ambedkar, because castes do not exist as an isolated unit on their own; they exist as a system.

Ambedkar analyses only those characteristics from the definitions of castes, which he regards as peculiar and of universal occurrence. For Senart, the 'idea of pollution' was a significant characteristic of caste. Ambedkar refuted this by arguing that by no means is it peculiar to caste. It usually originates in priestly ceremonialism and in the general belief in purity. Its connection with caste as an essential element may be ruled out because even without it, the caste system operates. He concludes that the idea of pollution is associated with caste only because priesthood and purity are old associates, and it is the priestly caste who enjoys the highest rank in the caste hierarchy. Ambedkar identified the absence of dining with those outside one's own caste as one of the peculiar characteristics in Nesfield's definition of caste. He points out that Nesfield had mistaken the effect for the cause. The absence of inter-dining is the effect of the caste system and not its cause. Further, Ketkar defines a caste in its relation to a system of castes. Ketkar identified two characteristics of caste: (a) prohibition of inter-marriage and (b) membership by autogeny. Ambedkar argues that these two aspects are not different because if inter-marriage is prohibited, the result is that membership is limited to those born within the group.

After critical evaluation of the various characteristics of caste as given by various thinkers, Ambedkar infers that prohibition or rather the absence of inter-marriage between people of different castes is the only viable characteristic that can be considered as the critical element of caste. Further, Ambedkar also observed that, among the Hindus, castes are endogamous, while *gotras* within a particular caste are exogamous. In spite of the endogamy of the castes, exogamy at the level of *gotra* is strictly observed. There are more rigorous penalties for those who break the laws of exogamy than for those who break the laws of

endogamy. It is understandable that exogamy cannot be prescribed at the level of caste because then caste, as a definite, identifiable unit, would cease to exist. Elaborating on the same point, Ambedkar argues that preventing marriages in the group creates a problem from within the group, which is not easy to solve.

The problem is that the number of individuals of either sex is more or less evenly distributed in a normal group, and they are of similar age. If a group desires to consolidate its identity as a caste, then it has to maintain a strict balance in the number of persons belonging to either sex. Maintenance of numbers becomes the primary goal because if a group wants to reserve the practice of endogamy, it is absolutely necessary to maintain numerical equality between marriageable individuals of the two sexes within the group. Ambedkar (1979:10) concludes, 'The problem of caste, then ultimately resolves itself into one of repairing disparity between the marriageable units of the two sexes within it.' What naturally happens is that there is a 'surplus' of either sex in society. If a man dies, his wife is 'surplus', and if a woman dies, her husband is 'surplus'. If the group does not take care of this surplus population, it can easily break the law of endogamy. Ambedkar argues that there are two ways in which the problem of 'surplus women' is resolved in society. 'Surplus women' may either be burnt on the funeral pyre of their deceased husbands, or strict rules of endogamy may be imposed on them. Since burning with her deceased husband is rather an impractical way of solving the problem of sex disparity, the prohibition of re-marriage is imposed on them or in other words widowhood is enforced on them.

Regarding the problem of 'surplus men', Ambedkar says that men have dominated society for centuries and enjoyed greater prestige than women. The same treatment, therefore, cannot be accorded to them. A widower can remain so for the rest of his

life, but given the sexual desire that is natural, he is a threat to the morals of the group, particularly if he leads an active social life and not as a recluse. He has to be, therefore, allowed to marry a second time with a woman who is not previously married. This is, however, a difficult proposition. If a widower is provided a second woman, then an imbalance in the number of women of marriageable age is created. A 'surplus man' can, therefore, be provided a wife who has not yet reached marriageable age, i.e., a minor girl. Ambedkar identifies four means by which numerical disparity between two sexes can be dealt with—burning of the widow with her deceased husband, compulsory widowhood, imposition of celibacy on the widower, and wedding of the widower to a girl who has not yet attained marriageable age. In Hindu society, the customs of *sati*, prohibition of widow remarriage, and marriage of minor girls are practiced. A widower may also observe *sannyasa* (i.e., renounce the world). These practices take care of maintaining the numerical balance between both sexes, born out of endogamy.

For Ambedkar, the question of the spread and origin of caste are not separated. According to Ambedkar, the caste system has either been imposed upon the docile population of India by a lawgiver as a divine dispensation, or it has developed according to some law of social growth peculiar to the Indian people. Ambedkar refutes the notion that the law of caste was given by some lawgiver. Manu is considered to exist. Even if he existed, the caste system predates Manu. No doubt Manu upheld it and philosophized about it, but he certainly did not and could not ordain the present order of Hindu society. His work ended with the confiscation of existing caste rules and the preaching of caste *dharma* (duties), obligations and conduct associated with each caste. Ambedkar rejects the argument that the Brahmin created the caste. He maintains that it was necessary to dismantle this belief because there still is a strong belief in the minds of orthodox

Hindus that the Hindu society was molded into the framework of the caste system and that it is consciously crafted in the *shastras* (the sacred texts). It may be noted that the teaching and preaching of *shastras* are the prerogative of the Brahmins (Ambedkar 1979).

Ambedkar agrees with the second argument, i.e., of some law of social growth peculiar to Indian people about the spread of the caste system. According to Western scholars, the bases of origin of various castes in India are occupation, survival of tribal organizations, the rise of new belief systems, cross breeding and migrating (Ambedkar 1979: 17). The problem, according to Ambedkar, is that the aforesaid nuclei also exist in other societies and are not peculiar to India. Ambedkar asked, ‘. . . why is it they did not “form” caste on other parts of this planet?’ At some stage, the priestly class detached itself from the rest of the body of people and emerged as a caste by itself. The other classes that were subject to the law of social division of labour underwent differentiation. Some of these classes got divided into bigger groups and some into smaller ones. According to Ambedkar,

This sub-division of a society is quite natural. But the unnatural thing about these sub-divisions is that they have lost the open-door character of the class system and have become self-enclosed units called castes. The question is: were they compelled to close their doors and become endogamous, or did they close them of their own accord (Ambedkar 1979: 18)?

Ambedkar submitted a double line of answer,

Some closed their door: Others found it closed against them. The one is a psychological interpretation and the other is mechanistic, but they are complementary and both are necessary to explain the phenomenon of caste-formation in its entirety (Ambedkar 1979: 18).

Explaining the psychological interpretation of endogamy, Ambedkar opined that endogamy was popular in the Hindu society. Since it had originated from the Brahmin caste, it was wholeheartedly imitated by all the non-Brahmin subdivisions or classes, who, in their turn, became endogamous castes. Ambedkar quotes Tarde's law of imitation in this context. According to Tarde, 'imitation flows from higher to lower'. Second, 'the intensity of imitation varies inversely in proportion to distance. . . . Distance is understood here in its sociological meaning' (Ambedkar 1979: 19).

Ambedkar (1979: 19) points out that some castes were formed by imitating others because the crucial conditions for the formation of castes by imitation existed in Hindu society. He feels that (i) that the source of imitation must enjoy prestige in the group and (ii) that there must be 'numerous and daily relations' among members of the group. Ambedkar opined that the Brahmin is treated as next to God in Indian society. His prestige is unquestionable, and he is the fountainhead of all that is good. He is idolized by scriptures; therefore, 'Such a creature is worthy of more than mere imitation, but at least of imitation; and if he lives in an endogamous enclosure should not the rest follow his example?' He argues that the imitation of non-Brahmins of those customs, which supported the structure of caste in these nascent days until it became embedded in the Hindu mind and persists even today, is testimony to the fact that imitation is the cause of the formation of caste. The customs of *sati*, enforced widowhood, and marriage of girls are followed in one way or the other by different castes. Ambedkar opines,

Those castes that are nearest to the Brahmin have imitated all the three customs and insist on the strict observance thereof. Those that are less near have imitated enforced widowhood and girl marriage; others, a little further off, have only girl marriage and those furthest of have imitated only the belief in the caste Principle' (Ambedkar, 1979: 20).

ANNIHILATION OF CASTE

Ambedkar analyses the steps taken by the socialists to annihilate the caste system through economic development and reforms. He questions the wisdom of socialists who professed that acquiring economic power is the only motive by which man is actuated, and economic power is the only kind of power that one can exercise effectively over others. He opined that the social status of an individual by itself often becomes a source of power. He suggests that religion, social status, and property are all sources of power and authority that come into play into different situations. Ambedkar feels that without bringing freedom in the social order, one cannot bring about economic change. He also cautioned the socialists that the proletariat or the poor do not constitute a homogeneous category. They are divided not only on the basis of their economic situation but also on the basis of caste and creed. They cannot, therefore, unite against those who exploit them.

According to Ambedkar (1979: 46),

It seems to me that, other things being equal, the only thing that will move one man to take such an action is the feeling that other men with whom he is acting are actuated by a sense of equality, fraternity, and, above all, justice. Men will not join in a revolution for the equalization of property unless they know that after the revolution is achieved they will be treated equally and that there will be no discrimination of caste and creed. . . . The assurance must be the assurance proceeding from much deeper foundations, namely, the mental attitude of the compatriots towards one another in their spirit of personal equality and fraternity.

Seen in the above light the elimination of caste through economic reform is not tenable; hence, socialists would have to deal with hierarchy in the caste system first before effecting economic change and annihilation of caste.

After discussing the strategies of annihilation of caste by

socialists, Ambedkar explains that caste is not a physical object like a wall of bricks or a line or barbed wire that prevents the Hindus from free social interaction. Caste is a notion; it is a state of the mind. If someone wants to break the caste system, he/she has to attack the sacredness and divinity of the caste. Ambedkar believed that the real way to annihilate the caste system is

to destroy the belief in the sanctity of the *shastras*. How do you expect to succeed, if you allow the *shastras* to continue to mould the beliefs and opinions of the people? Not to question the authority of the *shastras*, to permit the people to believe in their sanctity and their sanctions and to blame them and criticize them, for their acts as being irrational and inhuman, is an incongruous way of carrying on social reform. Reformers working for the removal of untouchability including Mahatma Gandhi, do not seem to realize that the acts of the people are merely the results of their beliefs inculcated upon their minds by the *shastras* and that people will not change their conduct until they cease to believe in the sanctity of the *shastras* on which their conduct is founded' (Ambedkar 1979: 68).

Ambedkar further added that the caste system has two aspects—it divides men into separate communities, and it places the communities in a graded order, one above the other, as discussed earlier. The higher the grade of a caste is, the greater the number of religious and social rights. Now, this gradation makes it impossible to organize a common front against the caste system. Castes form a graded system of sovereignties, high and low, who are jealous of their status and know that if a general dissolution happened, some of them would lose more prestige and power than others. It is, therefore, not possible to organize a mobilization of the Hindus (Ambedkar 1987(c)).

Can you appeal to reason and ask the Hindus to discard caste as being contrary to reason? Here, Ambedkar quotes Manu: 'So far as caste and *varna* are concerned, not only the *shastras* do not

permit the Hindu to use his reason in the decision of the question, but they have taken care to see that no occasion is left to examine in a rational way the foundations of his belief in caste and *varna*' (Ambedkar 1979:73). Ambedkar argues that if one wanted to dismantle the caste system, then one would have to implement laws to change the caste system. He proposes the following reforms within the Hindu religion in order to dismantle the caste system:

- (i) There should be one and only one standard book of Hindu religion, acceptable to all Hindus and recognized by all Hindus;
- (ii) It would be appropriate if priesthood among Hindus was abolished, failing which the priesthood should at least cease to be hereditary. Every person who professes to be a Hindu performs rituals as a priest unless he has passed an examination prescribed by the state and holds permission from the state to practice;
- (iii) no ceremony performed by a priest who does not hold the permission would be deemed to be valid in law, and a person who officiates as a priest without the permission should be penalized;
- (iv) a priest should be the servant of the state and should be subject to the disciplinary action by the state in the matter of his morals, beliefs; and (v) the number of priests should be limited by law according to the requirements of the state (Ambedkar 1979: 77).

These, according to Ambedkar, would provide the basis for the establishment of a new social order based on liberty, equality and fraternity, in short, with democracy.

Having analysed the exploitative nature of the Hindu social order born out of *varnas*, castes and sub-castes, Ambedkar gives his own vision of an ideal social order. He looked forward to a society based on liberty, equality and fraternity. Fraternity creates more channels for association and sharing experiences; this helps in establishing an attitude of respect and reverence among individuals towards fellowmen. For Ambedkar, liberty benefits the people by giving them freedom of choice of occupation. Lastly, we need

equality because we are aware that all men are not equal in terms of their physical and economic endowments. They are not equal on the basis of parental care, education, accumulation of scientific knowledge and finally, in their own efforts. Therefore, against an individualistic standpoint, Ambedkar emphasized the point that '... we should make people as equal as far as possible at the very start of the race' (Ambedkar 1979: 57-78). Second, he reiterates that 'Statesmen ... must follow some rough and ready rule and that rough and ready rule is to treat all men alike not because they are alike but because classification and assortment is impossible' (ibid.). We will discuss this issue in Chapter 3 in detail. Hence, we can see how Ambedkar envisaged a democratic society by annihilating caste.

CONCLUSION

To conclude, we can argue that Ambedkar has propounded a very novel theoretical and philosophical perspective of Hindu social order, which comprises the place of the individual, *varna* and caste system in a hierarchical manner.

This social order should be first analysed at the *varna* level, then at the caste and last, how to annihilate it. We also come to know that inequality in the Hindu social order is not simple inequality, as has been explained by other social scientists; rather, it is graded inequality. This is the original idea of Ambedkar. Further, his proposition that castes exist as a system rather than an independent unit is also unique. His philosophical and anthropological explanation of the origin of caste with 'surplus men', 'surplus women' and the imposition of endogamy over exogamy is an exceptional insight. Further, quoting sociologist Tarde's law of imitation as the reason for the spread of the caste system, Ambedkar has opened a new vantage point for research in this area. With all these propositions, conceptualizations

and formulations, Dr. Ambedkar has presented himself as a sociologist par excellence. On this basis, he can be called one of the founders of Indian sociology.

In the same vein, we have also observed that according to Ambedkar, the caste system is an oppressive, exploitative system that restricts opportunities and creates imbalances and inequalities, and therefore, he thinks it should be annihilated. Ambedkar suggested inter-caste marriage, questioning the sanctity of the sacred texts of the Hindu social order, which provides legitimacy to the structure of caste and abolition of the institution of traditional priesthood as some of the measures for annihilating the caste system in India. Ambedkar concludes by emphasizing the fact that, 'in my opinion only when the Hindu society becomes a casteless society it can hope to have strength to defend itself' (Ambedkar 1979: 80). Therefore, for Ambedkar caste was not only a project for emancipation of the Dalits but it was also for strengthening the nation as well.

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Social Justice: An Ambedkarian Perspective

INTRODUCTION

This chapter conceptualizes the idea of ‘social justice’ in Ambedkar’s thought. Taking reference from Plato and Rawls, the chapter evolves the idea of social justice with the help of Ambedkar’s writings and speeches published posthumously by the Maharashtra government. In doing so, it has identified five basic principles of ‘social justice’ in the social thought of Ambedkar. These are—first related to the relationship between the individual and society, and second the establishment of a just social order. According to Ambedkar, a just social order can only be developed on the basis of equality, liberty, and fraternity. That means his scheme of social justice includes the establishment of a just social order, which should be based on equality, liberty, and fraternity, which he has drawn from his master, the Buddha.

The third principle of social justice in Ambedkar’s thought is associated with the fact that democracy in a society should not be restricted only to political spheres. In other words, a democracy will not be a true democracy—if individuals have only political equality. Political equality here means that they all can cast their votes freely. No doubt, in such a condition, according to him, there will be the principle of ‘one man one vote, one vote one value’ in politics. However, a democracy will be true democracy only when equality is also extended in social and economic spheres along with the political sphere. Hence,

we can argue that the establishment of a true democracy with social, economic and political equality is the third principle of social justice in Ambedkar's thought.

The fourth principle of Ambedkar's scheme of social justice includes its dispensation via constitutional means. He argued that if we want to strengthen democracy, then we should not adopt extra-constitutional mechanisms; instead, we should be steadfast in adherence to constitutional means for achieving our social and economic objectives. If we have constitutional means to meet our social, economic and political demand, we should not, as Ambedkar used to say, resort to unconstitutional measures like *satyagraha* (civil disobedience movements).

The fifth principle of social justice in Ambedkar's thought is dismantling the monopoly of the so-called 'upper castes'. In this regard, he believes that social justice cannot be enforced on its own; rather, it has to be made effective. And it can be made effective, according to Ambedkar, if and only if the Civil Administration of that society is not against the emergence of an egalitarian social order. In his vision, Indian Civil Services have been biased towards the old hierarchical social order. That is why he emphasized that if we have to make social justice effective, then we have to make our bureaucracy more representative.

In the following pages, we will elaborate on these points in detail.

THE CONCEPT OF SOCIAL JUSTICE

To begin with, Plato defined social justice as,

the principle of a society consisting of different types of men . . . who have combined the impulse of their need for one another and their concentration on their combination in one society and their concentration on their separate functions have made a whole, which is perfect because it is the product of the image of the whole of the human mind (Republic 368d quoted in Mohapatra 1999).

In modern times the term social justice was first used in 1840 by a Sicilian priest, Luigi Taparelli d'Azeglio. However, Antonio Rasmini Serbasti gave the term prominence in his work, *La Costituzione Civile Secodo La Giurtizia Sociale*, in the year 1848 (Noval 2000: 11 as quoted in Yadav 2006).

Further, in a series of articles beginning with *Justice as Fairness*, Rawls propounded his theory of justice. His theory is considered a contractual theory of justice as it applies to institutions and practices, and is based on the notions of fairness and reciprocity. Rawls believed that his theory of justice was an improvement over utilitarian accounts of justice as maximum welfare. Where the utilitarian theory of justice treats society as a collective person and aims at maximizing its satisfaction without regard for the gains and losses of actual persons, Rawls's conception treats society distributively, taking into account the autonomy and right to the satisfaction of each member. Rawls developed the following principles of justice:

1. Each person is to have an equal right to have the most extensive basic liberty compatible with a similar liberty for others.
- 2a. Social and economic inequities are arbitrary unless they are reasonably expected to be to the advantage of the representative man in each income class.
- 2b. Inequalities are to attach to positions and offices equally open to all. (Choptiany 1973: 146)

Therefore, while conceptualizing the theory of justice, according to Rawls,

... the principles ... would be chosen at least in preference to other traditional alternatives, by rational persons, in an original position of equality as their common conception of justice'. (ibid)

Similarly, taking a leaf from Rawls's theory of social justice, Beteille (2005: 417) argues, '... the fundamental issue in

distributive justice is equality; a more equal or at least a less unequal distribution of the benefits and of social cooperation.' He further opines that

In that sense, distributive justice to go beyond equality in the purely formal sense: equality before the law, seeks to go beyond equality in the purely formal sense: equality before the law, the equal protection of the laws, or even formal equality of opportunity. Its central concern is, in the language of Rawls, 'to address the bias of contingencies in the direction of equality'. . . . Any attempt to promote distributive justice must begin with a consideration of the existing inequalities in society. . . . It is essential to keep in sight both inequalities between individuals and disparities. Disparities between groups have been historically of great significance in Indian society.

Plato's and Rawls's concept of social justice would mean giving every man his due. However, a universal theory of social justice has not evolved either in the Western liberal philosophy or in the socialist and communist doctrine yet. Certain basic ingredients of the concept of social justice have already been projected through the international human rights document and the Indian constitution. Accordingly, the basic aim of social justice is to remove the imbalances in the social, political, and economic life of the people to create a just society. Regarding culture-specificity, the term social justice has a different meaning in Indian society. It means dispensing justice to those to whom it has been systematically denied in the past, to those historically subjected to social wrongs because of an established social structure.

SOCIAL JUSTICE IN AMBEDKAR'S WRITINGS

It is a fact that Ambedkar did not propound any specific definition or theory of 'Social Justice' per se. However, in the light of principles enshrined in the theories of 'social justice', as

propounded by Plato and Rawls, one could infer basic cultural and structural principles of social justice embodied in the thoughts of Ambedkar. These thoughts are eloquently portrayed in his writings and speeches published posthumously. Based on these, we can easily argue that Ambedkar has mentioned multiple principles for establishing an open and just social order, in general and Indian society, in particular. Therefore, with the help of these characteristics, we can carve out a social justice theory. If we succeed in doing that, then we can refer to it as Ambedkar's theory of social justice. Drawing upon the principles he has laid down in his writings and speeches through which social justice can be ensured to the masses, we can identify and underline five fundamental principles (Kumar 2008: 107):

1. Establishing a society where an individual becomes the means of all social purposes.
2. Establishment of society based on equality, liberty and fraternity.
3. Establishing a political, economic and social democracy.
4. Establishing a democracy through constitutional measures.
5. Establishing a democracy by breaking the monopoly of upper strata on political power.

RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN INDIVIDUAL AND SOCIETY

To achieve the goals mentioned above, he launched the long, arduous, multilayered movement specifically for the most neglected and marginalized groups of the Hindu society—the Dalits. Further, he also laid the foundation for disseminating social justice for every section of Indian society. Going by the principles of Ambedkar's theory of social justice, Ambedkar believed that social justice can be dispensed in a free social order in which an individual is an end in itself. Similarly, terms of associated lives between members of society must be regarded as founded on liberty, equality, and fraternity. In a way, these principles of social

justice are similar to those of social justice, as mentioned in Rawls's theory. Let us look at these principles in operation.

Arguing a case for open social order in his writings, Ambedkar emphasized that, generally, there are two fundamentals and essentials of free social order. He states,

The first is that the individual is an end himself, and that the aim and object of society is the growth of the individual and the development of his personality. Society is not above the individual; if the individual has to subordinate himself to society, it is because such subordination is for his betterment and only to the extent necessary (Ambedkar 1987(c): 95).

With this aim, Ambedkar rejected the village as a unit of governance and adopted the individual as its unit. He vehemently criticized the part played by village communities in history and congratulated the Drafting Committee for accepting individuals as the unit of governance (Ambedkar 1994: 61-2). Ambedkar had argued for the individual as the end itself as he was fully aware of the fact that

The Hindu social order does not recognize the individual as a centre of social purpose. . . . The Hindu social order is based principally on a class or *varna* and not on individuals. . . . The unit of Hindu society is not the individual Brahmin or the individual Kshatriya. . . . Even the family is not regarded by the Hindu social order as the unit of society except for the purposes of marriage and inheritance. . . . In the Hindu social order, there is no room for individual merit and no consideration of individual justice (Ambedkar 1987(c): 99).

SOCIAL JUSTICE: EQUALITY, LIBERTY, AND FRATERNITY

Ambedkar has always advocated for establishing a society based on the principles of liberty, fraternity, and equality. This has to be for every individual. It may be so because he understood that

social justice can be ensured to the members of the society only if the society is based on equality, liberty and fraternity. This is quite similar to the argument given by Plato, who opines that social justice is the principle in which individuals combine their efforts for others. This can happen when men are treated as equals. However, one is forced to argue that this can happen only when there is fraternity in society. For this, society has to be established on the basis of the three principles, that is 'liberty, equality and fraternity'. In this context, let us see what Ambedkar says. Explaining his notion of an ideal society, Ambedkar emphasized, '... my ideal would be a society based on Liberty, Equality and Fraternity' (Ambedkar 1979: 57).

Delineating the characteristics of fraternity, he opined,

An ideal society should be mobile, full of channels for conveying a change taking place in one part to another. In an ideal society, many interests should be consciously communicated and shared. There should be varied and free points and contacts with other modes and associations. In other words, there must be social endosmosis. This is a fraternity, which is only another name for democracy. Democracy is not merely a form of government. It is a primary mode of associated living, of conjoint communicated experience. It is essentially an attitude of respect and reverence towards followers (ibid).

Further, Ambedkar explains the notion and importance of liberty. In his words,

Few object to liberty in the sense of a right to free movement. There is no problem with liberty in the sense of the right to property, tools and materials as being necessary for earning a living, to keep the body in due state of health. Why not allow liberty to benefit by an effective and competent use of a person's power? However, the problem is that people who support liberty in the sense of right to life, limb and property would not readily consent

to liberty if it involves the liberty to choose one's profession (Ambedkar 1979: 57).

Ambedkar further argues that,

... to object to the liberty to choose a profession is to perpetuate slavery. For slavery does not merely mean a legalize form of subjection. It means a state of society in which some men are forced to accept other occupations which control their conduct. This condition is found even where there is no slavery in the legal sense. For instance, it is found in the society where caste system is prevalent because some persons are compelled to carry on certain prescribed calling which are not of their choice.

This brings us the notion of equality as deliberated by Ambedkar. According to him,

... The objection to equality may be sound and one may have to admit that all men are not equal. Equality may be a fiction but nonetheless accept it as the governing principle. A man's power is dependent upon (1) physical heredity (2) social inheritance or endowment in the form of parental care, education, accumulation of scientific knowledge, everything which enables him to be more efficient than the savage, and finally, (3) on his own efforts. In all these three aspects men are undoubtedly unequal. But the question is, shall we treat them as unequal because they are unequal? ... From the point of view of the individualist, it may be just to treat men unequally so far, their efforts are unequal. It may be desirable to give as much as incentives as possible to the full development of every one's powers. But what would happen if men were treated unequally as they are, in the first two respects? It is obvious that those individuals also in whose favor there is birth, education, family name, business connection and inherited wealth would be selected in the race. But selection under such circumstances would not be a selection of the abled. It would be the selection of the privileged. The reason, therefore, which forces that in the third respect we should treat men unequally demands, that in the first two respects we should treat men as equally as possible (Ibid.: 58).

In this context Ambedkar also explains why we cannot run away from equality. According to him,

. . . it can be urged that if it is good for the social body to get the most out and its members, it can get most out of them only by making them equal as far as possible at the very start of the race. That is one reason why we cannot escape equality. There is a second reason for accepting equality. A statesman is concerned with the vast majority of people. He has neither the time nor the knowledge to draw fine distinctions and to treat each equally, i.e., according to need or according to capacity. However desirable or reasonable and equitable treatment of men may be, humanity is not capable of assortment and classification. The statesmen, therefore, must follow some rough and ready rule and that ready and rough rule is to treat all men alike and not because they are alike but because classification and assortment are impossible. The doctrine of equality is glaringly fallacious but taking all in all, it is the only way a statesmen can proceed in politics which is a severely practicable affair, and which demands a severely practical test (Ambedkar 1979: 57-8).

ESTABLISHING DEMOCRACY POLITICAL, ECONOMIC AND SOCIAL

Here, it is interesting to note that Ambedkar's principles of social justice were not only philosophical and theoretical propositions rather, but he also tried to give them practical shape as well. That is why, after India's political independence, for dispensing social justice in the wake of emerging democracy in a hierarchically arranged society, Ambedkar discussed the ways and means to operationalize the principles of equality, liberty, and fraternity, which were considered to be cardinal principles of any democracy. In this regard, he argued in the constituent assembly that 'We must . . . not . . . be content with mere political democracy. We must make sure our political democracy is a social democracy as well' (Ambedkar 1994: 1216).

In the same vein, Ambedkar went on to define social democracy as well. In his own words,

What does social democracy mean? It means a way of life that recognizes liberty, equality, and fraternity as the principles of life. These principles of liberty, equality and fraternity should not be treated as separate items of trinity (Ambedkar 1994: 1216).

Another significant contribution of Ambedkar in the process of establishing a social democracy is his explanation of the nature of three cardinal principles of democracy, i.e., liberty, quality, and fraternity. He opined,

They form a union of trinity, in the sense that to divorce one from the other is to defeat the very purpose of democracy. Liberty cannot be divorced from equality; equality cannot be divorced from liberty. Nor can liberty and equality be divorced from fraternity.

Without equality, liberty would produce the supremacy of the few over many. Equality without freedom would kill individual initiative. Without fraternity, liberty and equality could not become a natural course of things. . . . We must begin by acknowledging the fact that there is a complete absence of two things in Indian society. One of these is equality. On the social plane, we have in India a society based on the principle of graded inequality, which means the elevation of some and the degradation of others. On the economic plane, we have a society in which there are some, who have immense wealth as against many, who live in abject poverty (Ambedkar 1994: 1216).

Finally, he cautioned the Indians on how to eradicate the conditions of persisting inequality and create cordial conditions about emerging equality, taking the help of social justice. In his own words,

On the 26 January 1950, we are going to enter into a life of contradictions. In politics, we will have equality, and in socio-economic life, we will have inequality. In politics, we will recognize

the principle of one man one vote, and one vote one value. In our social and economic life, we shall, because of our social and economic structure, continue to live this life of contradiction. How long shall we continue to live this life of contradictions? If we continue to deny it for long, we will do so only by putting our political democracy in peril. We must remove this contradiction at the earliest possible moment, or else those who suffer from inequality will blow up the structure of political democracy. . . . The second thing we want is recognition of the principle of fraternity. What does fraternity mean? Fraternity means a sense of common brotherhood of Indians—If Indians being one people. It is the principle that gives unity and solidarity to social life. It is a difficult thing to achieve (Ambedkar 1994: 1216-17).

DEMOCRACY THROUGH CONSTITUTIONAL MEASURES

Although initially, Ambedkar was skeptical of ensuring justice to the erstwhile excluded communities through bureaucracy, however, later on, he preferred the same by asking Dalits to claim their share in it. Going by the then-existing Hindu social order, Ambedkar expressed his anguish on the failure of delivery of justice to the excluded groups like the ex-untouchables. That is why he once opined,

It might have been brought that the principle of equal justice would strike a death blow to the established order. As a matter of fact, far from suffering any damage, the established order has continued to operate in spite of it. It might be asked why the principle of equal justice has failed to have its effect. The answer to this is simple. To enunciate the principle of justice is one thing. To make it effective is another thing. Whether the principle of equal justice is effective or not must necessarily depend upon the nature and character of the civil services, which must be left to administer the principle. If the civil services are, by reason of their class bias, the friend of the

established order and the enemy of the new order; the new order can never come into being.

That civil service in tune with the new order was essential for the success of the new order was recognized by Marx in 1871 in the formation of the Paris Commune and adopted by Lenin in the constitution of Soviet communism. Fortunately, the British government never cared about the personnel of the Civil Services. Indeed, it opened the gates of the administration to those classes who believed in the old established order of the Hindus in which the principle of equality had no place. As a result of this fact, India has been ruled by the British but administered by the Hindus' (Ambedkar 1989(a): 104).

Further, he argued,

The police and the Magistrate are sometimes corrupt. If they were only corrupt, perhaps things would not be so bad because an officer who is corrupt is open to purchase by either party. But the misfortune is that the police and magistrate are often more partial than corrupt. It is this partiality to the Hindus and his antipathy to the untouchables, which results in the denial of protection and justice to the untouchables (Ambedkar 1989(a): 105-6).

However, as time passed by, Ambedkar gradually became aware that social justice can be delivered through the government machinery and through constitutional means and therefore, Dalits have to be part of it. In this context, he wrote,

The power to administer law is not less important than the power to make laws. And the spirit of the legislators may easily be violated if not nullified by the machinery of the administrators. This is not the only reason why the depressed classes should show special concern for securing power of control over administration. Often-times, under pressure of work or under difficult circumstances, one has to leave a good deal of discretionary power in the hands of the heads of the administrative departments. The welfare of the people must greatly depend on how impartially this discretionary

power is exercised in a country like India, where the public service is exclusively manned by people of one community; there is a great danger of this vast discretionary power being used for the personal aggrandizement of a class. The best antidote against it is to insist on a proper admixture of caste and creeds, including the depressed classes, and there will be no difficulty in guaranteeing this safeguard to us by a clause in the constitution. Such protection you could have dispensed with if there was any chance of the depressed classes being represented in the future cabinets of the country. But there is not the remotest chance of this because the depressed classes will always remain in the minority. This makes it all the more necessary to insist upon such a guarantee (Ambedkar, 2003: 37).

Moreover, Ambedkar cautioned people that

If we wish to maintain democracy not merely in form, but also in fact, . . . we must hold fast to constitutional methods of achieving our social and economic objectives. It means we must abandon the bloody methods of revolution. It means that we must abandon the method of civil disobedience, non-cooperation, and *satyagraha*. When there was no way left for constitutional methods to achieve economic and social objectives, there was a great deal of justification for unconstitutional methods. But where constitutional methods are open, there can be no justification for these unconstitutional methods. These methods are nothing but the grammar of anarchy, and the sooner they are abandoned, the better for us (Ambedkar 1994: 1215).

BREAKING THE MONOPOLY OF UPPER STRATA

Ambedkar was also a proponent of freedom of the individual as well. Furthermore, even for the healthy future of the emerging Indian democracy, he wanted to strengthen social and economic equality along with political one. According to him, one of the ways to deliver social justice to the individual was by breaking

the monopoly of the upper strata. Ambedkar (1994: 1218) in this regard, opined,

. . . there can be no gainsaying that political power in this country has too long been the monopoly of a few. This monopoly has not merely deprived them of their chance of betterment; it has sapped them of what may be called the significance of life. These downtrodden classes are tired of being governed. They are impatient to govern themselves. This urge for self-realization in the downtrodden classes must not be allowed into a class struggle or class war. It would lead to a division of the House. That would be a day of disaster. For, as has been well said by Abraham Lincoln, a house divided against itself cannot stand very long. Therefore, the sooner the room is made for the realization of their aspiration, the better for the few, the better for the country, and the better for the maintenance of its structure. This can only be done by the establishment of equality and fraternity in all spheres of life. People are fast changing. . . . They are getting tired of the government by the people. They are prepared to have a government for the people. . . . If we wish to preserve the constitution in which we have sought to enshrine the principle of government of the people, for the people, and by the people, let us resolve not to be tardy in the recognition of the evils that lie across our path and which induce people to prefer government for the people to government by the people, nor to be weak in our initiative to remove them.

CONCLUSION

In conclusion we can argue that social justice generally deals with allocating scarce resources to a population. It is based on the idea of due process, impartiality, and distribution according to appropriate criteria (Marshall 1998: 333). We have also seen that the social justice debate starts with Plato and gets established with John Rawls's theory of the 'difference principle'. According to this principle, ' . . . inequalities in the distribution of scarce

goods are justified only if they serve to increase the advantage of the least favored groups of society' (ibid: 334). Taking clues from these basic elements of social justice from Plato and Rawls, this chapter has tried to search for these elements in the thoughts of Ambedkar found in his writings and speeches. These five characteristics of Ambedkar's social justice theory identified in this chapter, are one—individuals should be developed as free and independent agents, two—society should be based on equality, liberty, and fraternity; third—establishment of true democracy based on social, economic and political equality; fourth—establishing democracy through constitutional measures, and fifth—breaking the monopoly of the so-called upper-strata on political power.

It becomes clear that by propounding the principles above of social justice, Ambedkar wanted to deconstruct the existing socio-political structure of Indian society so that social justice can be effectively ensured to the masses. It can be argued that he must have propounded these principles because he was aware of the nature of Indian society in which a considerable percentage of the population has been cumulatively excluded from rights—social, economic, political, educational, religious, and even right to natural resources. It is interesting that Ambedkar did not evolve these aforesaid principles of social justice only as philosophical and theoretical prepositions. Instead, he backed and substantiated these principles with specific constitutional provisions. He did not believe that the political leaders or general masses would be interested in dispensing social justice to the excluded in the coming days. Hence, he enshrined them in the Constitution of India with their minutest of details, so that the excluded and depressed should be ensured of their rights, privileges, and entitlements as the citizens of the nation. The debate on social justice of this chapter will be elaborated further in the next chapter, that is, Ambedkar ideas of nation and nation building.

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Ambedkar's Ideas of Nation and Nation Building

From Sentimentality to Institutionalism

INTRODUCTION

In the preceding chapters, we have analysed the processes of reductionism and erasures associated with Ambedkar in various aspects of academia and creative fields. We are by now aware that mainstream media, academia, and intelligentsia have played a dominant and decisive role in reducing him only as a 'Dalit Leader'. At the most, a few progressive intellectuals have called him 'Chief Architect of the Indian Constitution'. Even in this address, many individuals were not comfortable, and that is why a high-profile journalist, who went on to become a Cabinet Minister of India, wrote a book-length volume to belittle Ambedkar's contributions to the making of the Indian constitution and, thereby, in the process of nation building.

It is also a fact that barring a few (Ram 1995), universities, intellectuals, and scholars have not engaged with Ambedkar's broad canvas of knowledge. His contributions in the spheres of understanding social categories of individual, caste, Hindu social order, problems of Indian women and Indian minorities, etc., have not been analysed in academia in detail. Above all, his ideas about nation and nation building have also been neglected in mainstream academia.

However, in the earlier chapter, we have already seen how the Dalit movement led by the Dalits themselves has provided Babasaheb Ambedkar visibility in contemporary times. Based on empirical data about the association of masses to a particular leader, the number of statues built by the individuals at their own expense, types of celebrations on his birth, conversion to Buddhism, and commemoration on his *mahaparinibbana* day, Ambedkar can be termed as the omnipresent organic leader of modern India. We have also observed how he has become famous and acceptable internationally.

The processes associated with Ambedkar's colossal personality have forced the mainstream academia and intelligentsia, in contemporary times, to nominally include him in the curriculum syllabus of social sciences at the higher education and in the competitive exams like Union Public Service Commission or State Services Commissions. However, even today, there is no reflexivity on his thoughts in university classrooms, and questions in the exams, on Ambedkar are still asked only as optional so that teachers and students can easily avoid reading him. However, a few social scientists have argued that Ambedkar is intellectually head and shoulders above most of the Congress leaders because of his more serious training in the London School of Economics and the Columbia University, New York. Anderson (2012: 52) has also highlighted that Ambedkar was the only intellectual who had written serious academic and rational work on the partition of India.

It is in this context that this essay tries to understand the notion of 'Nation' and his pioneering contributions to the process of nation building. The essay will broadly deal with the following aspects related to his conceptualization of nation:

- (a) Is India a nation?
- (b) Why is India not a nation?
- (c) What is a nation?

- (d) How a Nation would be built?
- (e) How to keep the unity and integrity of a Nation intact.

IS INDIA A NATION?

At the outset, Ambedkar, like many others, believed that India was not a nation but a nation in the making (Ambedkar 1994: 1217). He made this fact very clear as early as the 1930s during his conflict with Gandhi. According to Ambedkar, 'The Anglo-Indians were never tired of proclaiming that India was not a nation' (Ambedkar 1990(a): 29). It is true that the colonial administrators did not view the Indian subcontinent as one nation. Strachey (1888: 5) wrote, '... there is not and never was an India ... no Indian nation, no people of India.' In the same vein, Sheeley (1883: 255) commented, 'India is ... only a geographical expression like Europe or Africa. It does not make the territory of a nation and a language, but the territory of many nations and languages' (Strachey (1888) and Sheeley (1883), as quoted in Oommen 2000: 1). Ambedkar also opined that even Dr. Rabindranath Tagore, the national poet of Bengal also agreed that India was not a nation (Ambedkar 1990(a): 29). That is why he emphasized that,

First of all there is no nation of Indians in the real sense of the word. The nation does not exist; it is to be created, and I think it will be admitted that the suppression of a distinct and separate community is not the method of creating a nation (Ambedkar 1991(c): 412).

Again, while speaking on 26 November 1949 when the Constituent Assembly was going to pass the constitution of independent India Ambedkar argued that,

I[in the past] politically-minded Indians resented the expression 'the people of India'. They preferred the expression 'the Indian nation'. I am of the opinion that in believing that we are a nation, we are cherishing a great delusion (Ambedkar 1994: 1217).

WHY IS INDIA NOT A NATION?

In this context, it will be worth mentioning the main reasons why Ambedkar refused to accept that India was not a nation. It would also be worth considering how he defined the nation and his scheme for building the nation.

RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN HINDUS AND DALITS, HINDUS AND ABORIGINES

At the outset, Ambedkar wondered, 'How can people divided into several thousands of castes be a nation?' (Ambedkar 1994: 2017). Arguing at another place, Ambedkar highlighted the fact that castes were hurdles in the process of nation building. In his own words,

There is an utter lack among the Hindus of what the sociologists call 'consciousness of kind'. There is no Hindu consciousness of any kind. In every Hindu, the consciousness that exists is the consciousness of his caste. That is the reason why the Hindus cannot be said to form a society or a nation (Ambedkar 1979: 50).

Ambedkar further went on to explain why castes are anti-national. In his words, 'The castes are anti-national in the first place because they bring about separation in social life. They are anti-national also because they generate jealousy and antipathy between caste and caste' (Ambedkar 1994: 1217). Not only that, Ambedkar also underlined that, 'Caste is . . . the real explanation as to why Hindu has let the' thirteen million aborigines amid civilization as savage without giving him medical aid to reform them and make them good citizens (Ambedkar 1979: 53). Therefore, he suggested that, ' . . . we must overcome all these difficulties if we wish to become a nation in reality. For fraternity can be a fact only when there is a nation' (Ambedkar 1994: 1216-17).

RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN HINDUS AND MUSLIMS

If that was the case of the relationship between Hindus, Dalits, and Aborigines, Ambedkar further analysed whether ‘. . . there are enough affinities between Hindus and Muslims to constitute them into a nation. . .’ (Ambedkar 1990(a): 31). Ambedkar wondered,

Are there any common historical antecedents which Hindus and Muslims can be said to share together as a matter of pride or as matters of sorrow . . . so far, they have been just two-armed battalions warring against each other. There was no common cycle of participation for a common achievement. Their past is a past of mutual destruction—a past of mutual animosity, both in political as well as in religious fields (Ambedkar 1990(a): 35).

Ambedkar was clear that ‘while Hindus revere Prithviraj Chauhan, Rana Pratap, and Shivaji in history, the Muslims revere the likes of Mohammed Bin Qasim, Aurangzeb, etc.’ In the religious field, he argued, ‘. . . the Hindus draw their inspiration from the *Ramayana*, the *Mahabharat*, and *Geeta*. The Musalmans . . . derive their inspiration from Quran and Hadis’ (Ambedkar 1990: 36). Further, he reiterates, ‘In the absence of common historical antecedents, the . . . view that Hindus and Musلمان form one nation falls to the ground. To maintain it is to keep up a hallucination’ (Ambedkar 1990(a): 37).

RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN HINDU PROVINCES

Along with analysing the nature of relationships between people belonging to various castes and communities, Ambedkar also analysed the relationship between various provinces and the Hindu majority. He says,

The Hindu provinces have no common traditions and no interest to bind them. It cannot be pretended that the Sikhs have any

tenderness for the Bengalees or the Rajputs for the Madrasis. The Bengali loves only himself. The Madrasi is bound by his world. Maratha, who set out to destroy the Muslim empire in India, became a menace to the rest of the Hindus, whom they harassed and kept under their yoke for nearly a century. . . . On the other hand, the differences of language, race, and the conflicts of the past have been the most powerful forces tending to divide them (Ambedkar 1990(a): 12-13).

That is why Ambedkar concluded.

It is true that the Hindus are getting together, and the spirit moving them to become one united nation is working on them. But it must not be forgotten that they have not yet become a nation. They are in the process of becoming a nation (Ambedkar 1990(a): 13).

In the same vein, Ambedkar highlighted that

The Muslims have openly declared that they do not want to have any Central Government in India. . . . The Muslims feel that to accept one Central Government for the whole of India is consent to place the Muslims Provincial Government under a Hindu Central Government and to see the gain secured by the creation of Muslims Provinces by subjecting them to a Hindu Government (Ambedkar 1990(a): 12).

That is why, quoting Mohammad Iqbal's position at the Round Table Conference Ambedkar opined that, 'The Muslim way of escaping from the tyranny of Hindu Centre is to have no Central Government in India at all (ibid.: 12).

WHAT IS A NATION?

The logical question then is—If, according to Ambedkar, India is not a nation, then—What is a nation according to him? Before we answer that, we would like to engage ourselves with the idea of nation in general. Pecora (2001) has commented that ' . . . while the nation may be a human invention, one that has played an

enormous historical role in the last two centuries, it remains a piece of human history that has resisted firm definitions'. Therefore, it can be stated here that there is not a unified and final definition of 'nation'. However, taking the help of Patterson, we can define a Nation as,

a people, a folk, held together by some or all of such more or less immutable characteristics as common descent, territory, history, language, religion, way of life, or other attributes that members of a group have from birth onward (Patterson 1975: 181).

On the other hand, Jaffrelot (2002: 7) uses Marcel Mauss's definition of the nation to define it

. . . as forming a nation a society materially and morally integrated with a stable, permanent centralized political power, well-established borders, a relative moral and cultural unity of its inhabitants who consciously adhere to the state and its laws.

The significant aspect of this definition according to Jaffrelot is, 'This definition rules out the presence of any intermediary bodies, be they linguistic groups or religious communities'. However, in the same vein, Jaffrelot extensively quotes Ernest Gellner to refute Marcel Mauss's notion of 'nation'. According to him,

The primordialist has been strongly criticized by Ernest Gellner, for whom 'Men do not become nationalists from sentiments or sentimentality, atavistic or not, well-based or myth founded: They become Nationalist through genuine, objective, practical necessity, however obscurely recognized.' In his theory of nationalism, Gellner assumes that there is always an unequal distribution of economic resources across the territory of a state. People 'B', originating from a deprived region, ask for its share, but another group, 'A', which is relatively more prosperous, resists this demand to retain the monopoly of its privileged situation. Therefore, it exercises discrimination toward 'B' put forward as a pretext for its racial or cultural inferiority. Then the member of group 'B' is bound to revolt and' . . .

their discontent can find 'national' expression: the privileged are manifestly different from themselves, even if the shared 'nationality' of the under-privileged men from B starts off from a purely negative trait, i.e., shared exclusion from privilege and from the 'nation' of the privileged. For Gellner, it is in these situations that 'culture, pigmentation, etc., become important: Provide means of exclusion for the benefit of the published off identification, etc., for the under-privileged [. . .] Nationalism is not the awakening of nations to self-consciousness: It invents nations where they do not exist—but it does need some pre-existing differentiating marks to work on, even if, as indicated, they are purely negative (Jaffrelot 2002: 10).

However, it is interesting to note that sociologists like T.K. Oommen (2000: 1-18) argue that 'Indian Nationalism' was conceptualized under British colonialism and acquired broadly seven shades. These were: Nation as an ancient civilization, as composite culture, as a political entity, as a religious entity, as a geographical and religious entity, as a collection of linguistic entities, and as the unity of the little and great nation. To add further, the first three conceptualizations existed during the pre-Partition period. The fourth existed during the struggle for independence and continues still. The last three conceptualizations were the projects that emerged after Independence. Oommen says,

All available facts and experiences suggest that the two most critical elements in Nation formation are territory and language. These could be ancestral or adopted. Thus, if a people have a common homeland and adopt a common language, they could become a nation. Such an effort was made and is being pursued in India (Oommen 2000: 8).

SENTIMENTALITY AND AMBEDKAR'S NOTION OF NATION

Taking a leaf, Ambedkar rejected race, language, and country as a basis for constituting a nation. He argued, 'As a matter of historical experience, neither race nor language nor country has

sufficed to mold people into a nation' (Ambedkar 1990(a): 34). Quoting Renan, he argued,

that race must not be confused with nation The truth is there is no pure race. . . . Racial facts, important as they are in the beginning, have a constant tendency to lose their importance. Human history is essentially different from zoology. Race is not everything, as it is in the sense of rodents and felines (ibid: 34).

As for language,

Language invites reunion; it does not force it. The United States, England, Spanish America, and Spain speak the same language and do not form a single nation. On the contrary, Switzerland, which owes her stability to the fact she was founded by the assent of her sever counts three or four languages. In man, there is something superior to language-will. The will of Switzerland to be united despite the variety of her language is a much more important fact than a similarity of language, often obtained by persecution (ibid: 34).

As to a common country, Ambedkar quoted Renan,

It is no more the land than the race that makes a nation. The land provides a substratum, the field of battle and work; man provides the soul; man is everything in forming that sacred thing called a people. Nothing of a material nature suffices for it (ibid: 34).

Having shown that race, language, and country do not suffice to create a nation, Ambedkar quoted Renan to point out what is more necessary to constitute a nation. According to Renan:

A nation is a living soul, a spiritual principle. Two things, which in truth are but one, constitute the soul, this spiritual principle. One is in the past, the other in the present. One is the common possession of a rich heritage of memories; the other is the actual consent, the desire to live together, the will to preserve worthily the undivided inheritance that has been handed down. . . . The

nation, like the individual, is the outcome of a long past of efforts, sacrifices, and devotion. . . . A heroic past, great men, and glory—form the social capital upon which a national idea may be founded. To have common glories in the past, a common will in the present: to have done great things together, to will to do the like again,—such are the essential conditions for the making of a people (Renan quoted in Ambedkar 1990(a): 35).

Furthermore, Renan argues that:

In the past, an inheritance of glory and regrets to be shared; in the future, alike ideal to be realized; to have suffered, rejoiced, and hoped together; all these things are worth more than custom houses in common and frontiers in accordance with strategical ideas; all these can be understood despite diversities of race and language . . . suffering in common is a greater bond of union than joy. Regarding national memories, mournings are worth more than triumphs; they impose duties and demand common effort (Renan, quoted in Ambedkar 1990(a): 35).

Such are the characteristics of the nation, according to Ambedkar, which is identical to the definition of Mauss, as discussed above, which is without any markers of religion, race, language, or territory but instead based on sentiments or will.

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN NATIONALITY AND NATIONALISM

Apart from giving the characteristics of a nation, Ambedkar went on to differentiate between nationality and nationalism. Accordingly,

. . . there is a difference between nationality and nationalism. They are two different psychological states of the human mind. Nationality means 'Consciousness of Kind' awareness of the existence of that tie of Kinship (Ambedkar 1990(a): 39).

Further, he has explained that

Nationality is a social sentiment. It is feelings of a corporate sentiment of oneness that make those who are charged with it feel that they are kith and kin. This national feeling is a double-edged feeling. It is at once a feeling of fellowship for one's own kith and kin and an anti-feeling for those who are not one's own kith and kin. It is a feeling . . . which, on the one hand, binds together those who have it, so strongly that it overrides all differences arising out of economic conflict or social gradation and, on the other, severs them from those who are not of their kind. It is a longing not to belong to any other group. This is the essence of what is called a nationality and national feeling (Ambedkar 1990(a): 31).

On the other hand, Ambedkar elucidated that 'Nationalism means 'the desire for a separate national existence for those who are bound by this tie of kinship . . . there cannot be nationalism without the feeling of nationality being in existence' (Ambedkar 1990(a): 39). It is here that Ambedkar highlighted the relationship between Nationality and Nationalism as well. According to him, although nationalism cannot exist without nationality,

. . . the converse is not always true. The feeling of nationality may be present, and yet the feeling of nationalism may be quite absent. . . . For nationality to flame into nationalism, two conditions must exist. First, there must arise the will to live as a nation. Nationalism is a dynamic expression of that desire. Secondly, there must be a territory which nationalism could occupy and make it a state and cultural home of the nation (Ibid.: 39).

AMBEDKAR'S SCHEME OF NATION BUILDING: A SHIFT TOWARDS INSTITUTIONALISM

If we analyse the idea of the Indian nation in the light of the characteristics of the nation as discussed above, two things become amply clear. On the one hand, there is an utter lack of national feeling between Dalits, Other Backward Castes, Aborigines, and

the so-called upper-caste Hindus. On the other hand, there is no common antecedent between Muslims and Hindus. Third, Indian women were also subjugated and were excluded from social, political, and economic institutions because of caste and patriarchy. In this way, we can conclude from the aforesaid analysis that Ambedkar identified a lack of nationality hence a lack of fraternity within the aforesaid groups. Probably, it is here Ambedkar is moving away from the notion of the nation based on sentimentality to the notion of nation as given by Gellner, who has argued that people become because of genuine, objective, practical necessity, 'nation' may emerge from 'shared exclusion' and 'culture, pigmentation, etc.' which provides means of identification for the under-privileged class (Gellner, quoted in Jaffrelot 2002: 10).

Jaffrelot (2002) has used this aforesaid theory to prove the separatism of Muslims in British India, the crystallization of Bengali nationalism in Pakistan, and the assertion of Sindhis in Pakistan. Hence, if we must integrate these separatist tendencies emerging out of 'genuine objective and practical necessity' and 'shared exclusion' then we need to provide people with those necessary conditions that can subside their separatist assertion for an independent state. We have discussed the case of Hindu women here separately however they should be considered as a subsection of Hindu society only. In the light above the writer of this article is of the view that one must take the following steps for nation building.

FOUR CHARACTERISTICS OF NATION BUILDING

REALIZATION INDIA IS NOT A NATION

The first step in Ambedkar's scheme of nation building is the realization of the fact that India was not a nation. In his words,

The sooner we realize that we are not as yet a nation in the social and psychological sense of the word, the better for us. For then only we shall realize the necessity of becoming a nation and seriously think of ways and means of realizing the goal (Ambedkar 1994: 2017).

FORGETFULNESS

The second step in the process of nation building will be forgetting the turbulent and warring past. In this context, taking a clue from Renan, Ambedkar emphasized the importance of forgetfulness as a factor in the creation of a nation that can be observed in France, where the union of Northern and Southern France took place despite a century of conflict. But today, no one has forgotten it, and they both have become one nation. Therefore, Renan concluded that 'the essence of the nation is that all its individuals should have things in common; and also, that all of them should hold many things in oblivion' (Renan quoted in Ambedkar 1990(a): 37). Perhaps, Ambedkar was using this fact for both so-called upper caste Hindus and Dalits on the one hand, and for Hindus and Muslims, on the other. Although a very difficult proposition, Ambedkar proposed expecting that all the sections of the Indian society would forget their past of animosity and hatred to make a positive beginning.

FREEDOM OF SERVILE CLASSES IS ALSO A REALITY

The third aspect of Ambedkar's scheme of nation building was that all the subjugated collectivities should be granted their legitimate rights so that they should be free from subjugation. In his own words,

Philosophically it may be possible to consider a nation as a unit, but sociologically it cannot but be regarded as consisting of many classes and the freedom of the nation if it is to be a reality must vouchsafe that the freedom of the different classes comprised in it,

particularly those who are treated as servile classes (Ambedkar 1991(c): 201-2).

BREAKING THE MONOPOLY OF THE GOVERNING ELITE

The fourth characteristic of Ambedkar's scheme of nation building was dismantling the privileges of the governing elite and breaking their monopoly on 'political power'. He cautioned the Constituent Assembly about the dangers of a tiny group of people monopolizing power. He had opined,

Political power in this country has too long been the monopoly of a few. This monopoly has not merely deprived them of their chance of betterment; it has sapped them of what may be called the significance of life. These downtrodden classes are tired of being governed. They are impatient to govern themselves (Ambedkar 1994: 1218).

Ambedkar was trying to draw a parallel between the ruling elites of French and Japanese society, and their role in the process of nation building after the revolution in their respective countries with the ruling elite of Indian society. In Ambedkar's words,

It would be instructive to compare the attitude of the governing class in India with the attitude taken by the governing class in other countries in times of crisis. . . . In France, when the Revolution broke out and demanded equality, the governing class in France [Clergy and Nobles] voluntarily came forward to give up its powers and its privileges and to merge itself into the mass of the nation. . . . It was impossible. . . . Yet a good part of them agreed to the demands of the commons and gave France a constitution based upon liberty, equality, and fraternity (Ambedkar 1991(c): 225).

The attitude of the governing classes in Japan during the period between 1855 and 1870—a period in which Japanese people were transformed from a feudal society into a modern nation was even

more patriotic than the attitude of the governing classes in France . . . there were four classes in Japanese Society (1) The Daimyos, (2) The Samurai, (3) The Hemin or the common folk and (4) The Eta or the outcastes standing one above the other in order of graded inequality. . . . The Daimyos and the Samurai realized that it was impossible to transform this feudal society, with its class composition and class rights, into a modern nation with equality of citizenship. Accordingly, the Daimyos, charged with the spirit of nationalism and anxious not to stand in their way of national unity, came forward to surrender their privileges and to emerge themselves in the common mass of people (Ambedkar. 1991(c): 225-6).

The governing class in India has no such intention of making any sacrifice on the altar of Indian freedom. Instead of surrendering its privileges in the name of nationalism, the governing class in India is using or misusing the slogan of nationalism to maintain its privileges. Whenever the servile classes ask for reservations in the legislatures, in the Executive, and public services, the governing class raises the cry of nationalism in danger. People are told . . . all questions regarding reservations . . . are inimical to national unity and therefore . . . a sin to stand out for such reservation and create dissension. . . . The governing class in India does not merely refuse to surrender its power and authority; it never loses an opportunity to pour ridicule on the political demands of the servile classes (Ambedkar 1991(c): 226).

Under these circumstances, along with the 'representative government' for all Indians, Ambedkar wanted four different collectivities that were excluded or denied their legitimate rights to be included directly in the institutions of governance and thereby into the mainstream of Indian society so that the nation could evolve. In other words, the said collectivities should be granted their legitimate rights, which were it was due to them. Though it is a fact that Ambedkar had raised a host of other issues that were significant in the process of nation building, here we are restricting ourselves to his struggle to establish

the rights and representation of the following four collectivises. The four collectivises that come to mind and which form part of Ambedkar's core ideas of nation and nation building include:

REPRESENTATIVE GOVERNMENT
FOR ALL INDIANS

Dalits (ex-Untouchables)
Backward Castes/Classes
Muslims and other minorities
Women, in general, and Hindu women, in particular.

A REPRESENTATIVE GOVERNMENT
FOR INDIANS

Ambedkar explained that the British denied Indians representative government on the pretext of division in the population on the lines of caste and creed. However, Ambedkar contested this argument by giving a counterargument that if Indian society is not fit for representative government because it is divided on caste and creed, then how can American Society be fit for representative government? The American population is divided not only politically but also based on scientific, industrial, and religious aims and attitudes. Moreover, the US population is also divided based on language, religion, moral codes, and traditions. Finally, Ambedkar also highlighted that American society too has a different population of Poles, Dutch, Swedes, Germans, Russians, etc. Despite aforesaid divisions, if American society was fit to have a representative government, then why not India (Ambedkar 1979: 248)?

Second, Ambedkar went on to show that the division of Indian society is qualitatively different than the division existing in American society. He highlighted the fact that, unlike American Society, the Indian population is divided because they do not

have common aims, beliefs, aspirations, knowledge, common understanding, or what sociologists call like-mindedness to form a community (Ambedkar 1979: 248-9). According to him, to be like-minded with others is to be in communication with them and to participate in their activity. In this way, each group may create its own distinctive type of like-mindedness.

But where there are more groups than one to be brought into a political union, there would be conflict among different like-mindedness. So long as the group remains isolated, the conflict is bound to continue and prevent the harmony of action. It is the isolation of the groups that is the chief evil in India. The evil ceases to exist where there is endosmosis because it allows people to re-socialize their attitude. In place of the old, it creates a new like-mindedness, which is the representatives of the interests, aims, and aspirations of all the groups concerned. Hence, he concluded that 'Like-mindedness is essential for a harmonious life, social or political, and this depends upon the extent of communication, participation, or in a word, endosmosis' (Ambedkar 1979: 49). Hence, Ambedkar emphasized the legitimate and functional need of representative government with the self-representation of various groups comprised in it for nation building.

DALITS AND THEIR RIGHTS AS A CITIZEN

At the outset, Ambedkar wanted to establish the rights of those people who did not have rights as citizens. Ambedkar quoted Jefferson, to whom '... politics was the only affair of policing by the State so that the rights of people were maintained without disturbance. ... The question is, what is there for the State to police if there are no rights?' That is why Ambedkar wanted to establish the rights of the Dalits, as they were not treated as citizens. Ambedkar also argued,

The untouchables are usually regarded as objects of pity but ignored in any political scheme on the score they have no interest to protect. And yet, their interests are the greatest. Not that they have large property to protect from confiscation. But they have their very persona confiscated. The socio-religious disabilities have dehumanized the untouchables, and their interests at stake are, therefore, the interests of humanity. The interests of property are nothing before such primary interests. . . . The untouchable is not even a citizen. Citizenship is a bundle of rights such as (1) personal liberty, (2) personal security, (3) right to hold private property, (4) equality before law, (5) liberty of conscience, (6) freedom of opinion and speech, (7) right to assembly, (8) right of representation in a country's Government and (9) right to hold office under the State (Ambedkar 1979: 255-6).

So, it is clear from the above that Ambedkar wanted to establish the rights of the Dalits at the outset so they did not feel excluded. Probably, he believed if the rights of the Dalits were established, they would not raise their voices for separate 'Achutistan' (Separate land for Achuts or Untouchable) (Kumar 2002 and Juergesnmeier 1982).

DALITS AND THE QUESTION OF THEIR SELF-REPRESENTATION

Ambedkar did not raise the problems related to the aforesaid categories in one go. Rather, he took their problem as and when the country faced a crisis regarding these groups. But certainly started his public life by highlighting the problems and issues of the Dalits (the ex-untouchables). Ambedkar wanted self-representation of the Dalits in the government, cabinet, bureaucracy, etc. Explaining its importance, Ambedkar argued in his written statement given to the Southborough Committee on the franchise in 1919 that

As the government is the most important field for the exercise of individual capacities, it is in the interest of the people that no person as such should be denied the opportunity of actively participating in the process of government. That is to say, popular government is not only government for the people but by the people. To express the same in a different way, the representation of opinions by itself is not sufficient to constitute popular government. To cover its true meaning it requires personal representation as well. It is because the former is often found without the latter that the Franchise Committee must see in devising the franchise and constituencies for a popular government in India, it provides for both, i.e., representation of opinions and representation of persons (Ambedkar 1979: 247).

INCLUSION OF DALITS, BACKWARDS,
AND MUSLIMS IN THE INSTITUTIONS
OF GOVERNANCE

Ambedkar not only asked for self-representation for every citizen of the country, but he also advocated for self-representation via reserved nominations for Dalits (the ex-untouchables), Backward Classes to whom he referred as non-Brahmins and Muslims. Why was the self-representation of Dalits, Backward Classes, and Muslims necessary? Ambedkar answered this question in a written representation submitted to the Simon Commission, also known as the Indian Statutory Commission, in the year 1928. To begin with, in his representation, Ambedkar expressed his concern over the domination of Brahmin and other allied castes in the public services of British bureaucracy in India (Ambedkar 1982: 394).

Ambedkar argued that when the 'Dalits, Mohammedans, and non-Brahmins ask for their representation, the Brahmins and the allied castes argue that the appointment should be done through competition'. Ambedkar questioned the very basis of

appointment through competition. He declared the aforesaid process as unfair. Why was it unfair? It was so because

Those circumstances presuppose that the educational system of the state is sufficiently democratic and is such that facilities for education are sufficiently widespread and sufficiently used to permit all classes from which good public servants are likely to be forthcoming to compete. Otherwise, even with the system of open competition, large classes are sure to be left out in the cold. This basic condition is conspicuous by its absence in India so that to invite Backward Classes to rely upon the results of competitive examinations as a means of entry into the public services is to practice delusion upon them (Ambedkar 1982: 395).

Therefore, this was the second reason for supporting the self-representation of Dalits and non-Brahmins, and Muslims in administrative institutions.

Discussing the administrative basis for reservation, he argued, 'Those who lay exclusive stress upon efficiency as the basis for recruitment to the administration appears to be nothing more than the process of applying the law as enacted by the legislative' (ibid.). However, according to Ambedkar,

Administration in modern times involves far more than the scrutiny of status for the sake of knowing the regulations of the state. Often under the pressure of time or for convenience, a government department is nowadays entrusted with wide power of rulemaking (ibid.).

Further, he argued that

It must be accepted as beyond dispute that such wide powers of rule-making affecting the welfare of large classes of people cannot be safely left into the hands of the administrators drawn from a particular class which as a matter of fact is opposed to the rest of the population in its motives and interests, does not sympathize with the living forces operating in them, is not charged with their wants, pains, cravings and desires and is inimical to their

aspirations, simply because it comes out best by the test of education (ibid.).

Therefore, Ambedkar preferred giving self-representation through nomination.

MORAL REASON FOR REPRESENTATION OF DALITS

According to Ambedkar, the third reason for self-representation, specifically for Dalits, was moral. This can be extended to backward classes and minorities as well. Highlighting the moral evils arising out of the exclusion of a person from the public service, Ambedkar quoted Gopal Krishna Gokhale. Gokhale had raised the same issue of exclusion of so-called upper caste Indians from British bureaucracy. Emphasizing the exclusion of Indians from public services, he opined that,

A kind of dwarfing or stunting of the Indians is going on under the present system. We must live all days of our lives in an atmosphere of inferiority and the tallest of us must bend so that the exigencies of the existing system may be satisfied. The upward impulse . . . is denied to us. The full height to which our manhood is capable of rising can never be reached by us under the present system. The moral elevation that every self-governing people feel cannot be felt by us. Our administrative and military talent must gradually disappear, owing to sheer disuse, till at last our lot, as hewers of wood and drawers of water in our own country is stereotyped (quoted in Ambedkar(1982: 397).

Drawing an analogy between the Brahmins and allied castes with the foreign agency, i.e., the British, Ambedkar (Ambedkar 1982: 395-6) argued:

Is it not open to the backward classes to allege against Brahmins and allied castes all that was alleged by the late Mr Gokhale on behalf of Indian people against the foreign agency? Is it no open to the

Depressed Classes, the non-Brahmins, and the Mohammedans to say that by their exclusion from the Public Service, a kind of dwarfing or stunting of their communities is going on? Can they not complain that as a result of their exclusion, they are obliged to live all the days of their lives in an atmosphere of inferiority, and the tallest of them has to bend in order that the exigencies of the existing system may be satisfied? Can they not assert that upward impulses which every schoolboy of a Brahmanical community feels that he may one day be a Sinha, a Sastri, a Ranade, a Pranjpe, and which may draw forth from him the best efforts of which he is capable are denied to them? Can they not indignantly assert that the full height to which their manhood is capable of rising can never be reached by them under the present system? Can they not lament that the moral elevation that every self-governing person feels cannot be felt by them and that their administrative talents must disappear owing to sheer disgust till at last their lot as hewers of wood and drawers of water in their own country is stereotyped? The answer to these queries cannot but be in the affirmative. If to exclude the advanced communities from entering into the public service of the country was a moral wrong, the exclusion of the backward communities from the same field must be a moral wrong and if it is a moral wrong it must be righted.

For the inclusion of Dalits and other marginal sections in the public services, Ambedkar also highlighted that the demand for the Indianization of public services did not rest on consideration of efficient administration; rather, it was condemned as it was found to be wanting in those qualities that make for human administration. It is, therefore, he pointed out that those who clamoured for the Indianization of public services are themselves opposed to the inclusion of the Depressed and Backward Classes (Ambedkar 1982: 395-6). That is why he proposed that

A certain number of vacancies in Superior Services, Class I, and Class II, and also in the Subordinate Services should every year be filled by a system of nomination with pass examination. . . . Such nomination shall be reserved to the Depressed Classes, the Moham-

medans and the Non-Brahmins in order of preference herein indicated until their numbers in the services reach a certain proportion (Ambedkar 1982: 398).

This was possibly the first time that anyone had made a demand for the representation of Dalits in the public services, though Ambedkar had already made a demand for their political representation as early as 1919. It is a fact that the, then, Indian National Congress did nothing worth mentioning for the self-representation of the Dalits during this period and even after the formation of its government in 1937. The major development of the period is attributed to Ambedkar serving as a member of the Viceroy's Executive Council. It was he who issued an office order in 1943 to reserve 8.33 per cent of places in the Central Government Services for the Dalits. In fact, this order, which reserved the posts for the Dalits, had replaced an earlier general order for general preference for the Dalits in their recruitment in the Services (Ambedkar 1990(a): 475).

NECESSITY OF SELF-REPRESENTATION

Why at all self-representation was necessary? According to Ambedkar, this was necessary because the aims, beliefs, aspirations, and knowledge of the caste Hindus and the Dalits differ. That means they do not have like-mindedness. In his own words, 'Between two Hindus, caste-like mindedness is more powerful than the like-mindedness due to their both being Hindus' (ibid.: 249). Therefore, he emphasized that there would be a conflict of interest between the Hindus and the Dalits and, hence, caste Hindus could never represent the interests and opinions of Dalits if the latter did not get self-representation.

Ambedkar wanted self-representation for the Dalits because he was also convinced that only the Dalits could voice these interests. In his own words,

as can be easily seen, they can be represented by the untouchables alone. They are distinctively their own interests, and none can truly voice them. . . . Untouchability constitutes a definite set of interests which the untouchables alone can speak for (ibid.: 256).

Second, the personal representation for the Dalits is also important because

A government for the people, but not by the people, is sure to educate some into masters and others into subjects. . . . To be specific, it is not enough to be electors only. It is necessary to be law-makers; otherwise, who can be law-makers will be masters of those who can only be electors (ibid: 251).

That is why Ambedkar demanded not only a separate electorate for Dalits but also reservation in the cabinet as well. According to him,

Just as it is necessary that the Depressed Classes should have the power to influence governmental action by seats in the Legislature, so it is also desirable that the Depressed Classes should have the opportunity to frame the general policy of the government. This they can do only if they can find a seat in the cabinet. The Depressed Classes, therefore, claim that in common with other minorities, their rights to be represented in the Cabinet should be recognized. With this purpose in view, the Depressed Classes propose that in the Instrument of Instructions, an obligation shall be placed upon the Governor and the Governor-General to endeavour to secure the representation of the Depressed Classes in the Cabinet (Ambedkar 1991(c): 51-2).

GANDHI'S OPPOSITION TO DALITS' SELF-REPRESENTATION

Gandhi opposed the representation of the Dalits by special constituencies. He emphasized that the special representation of the untouchables (Dalits) 'Will create a division in the Hinduism which

I (Gandhi) cannot possibly look forward to with any satisfaction whatsoever' (Ambedkar 1991(c): 69). In fact, Gandhi was ready to accept the conversion of the Dalits to any other religion but was not ready to grant representation based exclusively on their votes though the same existed for the other minorities. In the words of Gandhi,

I do not mind Untouchables, if they so desire, being converted to Islam or Christianity. I should tolerate that, but I cannot possibly tolerate what is in store for Hinduism if there are two divisions set forth in the villages. Those who speak of the political right of Untouchables do not know their India, do not know how Indian Society is today constructed, and therefore I want to say with all the emphasis that I can command that if I were the only person to resist this thing, I would resist with my life (as quoted in Ambedkar 1991(c): 69).

INCLUSION OF MUSLIMS IN THE CONSTITUENT ASSEMBLY

Along with the representation of Dalits and backward castes in the structures of the state, Ambedkar was a strong votary of the inclusion of Muslims in the Constituent Assembly. His position came to the fore when he vehemently pleaded for their inclusion despite the Muslim League's announcement of their desire for a separate state. Ambedkar emphasized non-violent methods for the inclusion of Muslims in the Constituent Assembly. While speaking in the Constituent Assembly, which met for the first time on 9 December 1946, to move a resolution for making the Indian constitution, he, along with other members of the Constituent Assembly, argued that it would not be proper for the Assembly to proceed to deal with the resolution of framing the constitution of free India, while Muslim League was absent. He pointed out a particular para of the resolution that could prevent the Muslim League from entering the Constituent Assembly (Ambedkar 1994: 9-10).

Ambedkar was aware of the diversity and deep divide existing between Hindus and Muslims. Yet, he believed that every group should be included in the process of making decisions about the nation. In the constituent assembly, he explained

. . . Our difficulty is not about the ultimate future. Our difficulty is how to make the heterogeneous mass that we have today take a decision in common and march on the way, which leads us to unity. Our difficulty is not with regard to the ultimate; our difficulty is with regard to beginning . . . therefore, I should have thought that in order to make us willing friends, in order to induce every party, every section in this country to take on the road, it would be an act of greatest statesmanship for the majority party even to make a concession to the prejudices of people who are not prepared to march together and it is for that, that I propose to make this appeal. . . . Let us even make a concession to the prejudices of our opponents, bring them in, so that they may willingly join us on marching upon that road, which, as I said, if we walk long enough, must necessarily lead us to unity (Ambedkar 1994: 10).

To include the Muslim League in the process of the constitution, Ambedkar went on to argue,

. . . I want all of us to realize that whether we are right or wrong, whether the position that we take is in consonance with our legal rights. . . . This is too big a question to be treated as a matter of legal rights. It is not a legal question at all. We should leave aside all legal considerations and make some attempts where those who are not prepared to come will come. Let us make it possible for them to come (Ambedkar 1994).

Ambedkar was very much charged with the feelings of dignity and destiny of the nation that he advised the members of constituent assembly

. . . that another attempt may be made to bring about a solution of the dispute between the Congress and the Muslim League.

This subject is so vital, so important that I am sure it could never be decided on the mere basis of the dignity of one party or the dignity of another party (Ambedkar 1994: 12).

That is why he explained that

When deciding the destinies of nations, dignities of people, dignities of leaders and dignities of parties ought to be for nothing. The destiny of the country ought to count for everything (Ibid.).

Regarding Congress and Muslim League impasse Ambedkar was very much disturbed. He was very clear that the Congress and Muslim League problem should be solved as soon as possible. For which he played down the violence. He spoke, in the Constituent Assembly, with anguish,

... I do not know what plans the Congress party ... has in its mind? ... it seems to me there are only three ways by which the future will be decided. Either there shall have to be surrender by the one party to the wishes of the other. ... The other way would be ... negotiated peace, and the third way would be open war ... certain members of the Constituent Assembly ... are prepared to go to war (Ibid.: 13).

Refuting the option of war, Ambedkar (ibid.) expressed his anguish by emphasizing the point that:

I must confess that I am appalled at the idea that anybody in this country should think of solving the political problems of this country by the method of war. I do not know how many people in this country support that idea. A good many perhaps do, and the reason why ... they do is because most of them ... believe that the war ... would be a war on the British. ... But I have no hesitation ... to place before this house ... if that war comes in this country ... it will not be a war on the British. It will be a war on the Muslims. It will be a war on the Muslims or which is probably worse; it will be a war on a combination of the British and the Muslims.

In this conflict between Congress and the Muslim League, to bring down the temper of the house, Ambedkar quoted from Burke, who had rejected the idea of violence applied by the British in conquering the colonies of the United States and bringing them under their subjection arguing that '... the use of force is but temporary. It may subdue for a moment, but it does not remove the necessity of subduing again; and a nation is not governed which is perpetually to be conquered' (ibid.). Ambedkar further quoted Burke to highlight the fact of the uncertainty of terror in overpowering a nation. In the words of Burke,

... Terror is not always the effect of force and an armament is not a victory. If you do not succeed, you are without resources for conciliation; failing, force remains; but, force failing, no further hope of reconciliation is left. Power and authority are sometimes brought by kindness, but they can never be begged as alms by an impoverished and defeated violence (Ibid.: 13-14).

The third objection to force was '... that you impair the object by your very endeavours to preserve it. The thing you fought for is not the thing which you recover; but depreciated, sunk, wasted, and consumed in the contest' (ibid.: 14). Therefore, Ambedkar concluded,

If there is anybody who has in his mind the project of solving the Hindu-Muslim problem by force, which is another name of solving it by war, in order that the Muslims may be subjugated and made to surrender to the Constitution that might be prepared without their consent, this country would be involved in perpetually conquering them. The conquest would not be once and forever (Ibid.).

And suggested that the assembly should exercise the sovereign powers with wisdom because that is the only way by which we can carry every section of the country together, and that is the way to achieve unity (Ibid.).

REFERENDUM AGAINST ABRUPT PARTITION

Ambedkar, for the unity of the nation, instead of an abrupt partition of the country, mooted that 'The issue of Pakistan being one of self-determination must be decided by wishes of the people' (Ambedkar 1994: 392). The structure he proposed was the referendum of Muslims and non-Muslims and the limitation of districts with Muslim majority and non-Muslim majority areas (*ibid.*: 393). He argued that Muslims may stop with the delimitation of the boundaries of Pakistan or, if dissatisfied, may ask for a separate state (*ibid.*). Muslims may also agree to live under a common central government, say, for a period of ten years, and put the Hindus on trial. Hindus will have an opportunity to show that the minorities can trust them. The Muslims will learn from their experience how far their fears of the Hindu Raj are justified.

Ambedkar further explained that

There is another possibility also that the Musalmans of Pakistan having decided to separate forthwith may after a period become so disgusted with Pakistan that they might desire to come back and be incorporated into the Hindustan, and be one people subject to one single constitution (*Ibid.*: 393).

Last but not least, Ambedkar commented optimistically, 'I personally prefer . . . a separation for ten years and union thereafter' (*ibid.*). He preferred this because, in his opinion,

It would be much better that the Musalmans should have the experience of Pakistan Union after an experience of Pakistan would be stable and lasting. . . . The scheme takes account of the fact that the Hindu sentiment is against. . . . It also recognizes the fact that the Muslim demand for Pakistan may only be a passing mood (*Ibid.*: 394).

Despite the division and animosity between Congress and the Muslim League, Ambedkar (1994: 9) was convinced about the

unity and development of the nation. He told the Assembly optimistically

. . . I have got not the slightest doubt in my mind as to the future evolution and the ultimate shape of the social, political, and economic structure of this country. I know today, we are divided politically, socially, and economically. We are a group of warring camps, and I may go even to the extent of confessing that I am probably one of the leaders of such a camp. But, Sir, with all this, I am quite convinced that given time and circumstances, nothing in the world will prevent this country from becoming one. With all our castes and creeds, I have not the slightest hesitation that we shall, in some form, be a united people. I have no hesitation in saying that notwithstanding the agitation of the Muslim League for the partition of India, someday enough light would dawn upon the Muslims themselves, and they too will begin to think that a United India is better even for them.

Such was the optimism and commitment of Ambedkar when it came to the issue of nation building.

ESTABLISHING RIGHTS OF HINDU WOMEN

Apart from securing the rights of the Dalits, Other Backward castes, and Muslims in the processes of nation building, Ambedkar, as the first Law Minister of independent India, also introduced a Bill to safeguard the rights of Hindu women. However, one should keep in mind that it was not all of a sudden that Ambedkar made this effort for women's rights. Rather it was his long-time conviction to which he was giving a practical shape. For instance, Ambedkar had long back, in 1942, in the Scheduled Caste Federation's Women Conference, emphasized that 'I measure the progress of the community by the degree of progress of women of that community have made'. Further, Ambedkar had also analysed the wretched condition

of Indian women in Indian history through his influential articles like 'Manu's Madness'; 'The Change from Paternity to Maternity' (1987(b)) and 'The Woman and the Counter-Revolution' 1987(a). That is why he was instrumental in introducing certain bills for establishing the rights of women—like equal pay irrespective of sex (1991(d): 143), The Mines Maternity Benefit Act 1941 (ibid.: 264-6), and prohibiting employment of women underground in coal mines in 1946 (Ibid.: 958).

Together with the aforementioned efforts for analysing the status of Indian women and establishing rights for them, when he became the first law minister of independent India, Ambedkar introduced the bill, which envisaged securing dignified and equal status for Hindu women. It is interesting to note that there were rights of inheritance and maintenance in the Bill. There were laws against dowry. Instead of polygamy, Ambedkar introduced monogamy as the sanctioned way of marriage. The Hindu marriage became a contract instead of a sacrament. The consent of the wife was to be made compulsory in the event of the adoption of the child by the couple.

Ambedkar envisioned empowering Hindu women through all these rights and thereby building a strong nation. The Hindu Code Bill introduced in the parliament gives insight into what and how Ambedkar had thought about empowering Hindu women. He had mooted that

In the order of succession to a deceased Hindu, the Bill seeks to make four changes. One change is that the widow, the daughter, and the widow of a pre-deceased son are all given the same rank as the son in the matter of inheritance. In addition to that, the daughter is also given a share in her father's property (Ambedkar 1995: 6).

Ambedkar, in his proposed Hindu Code Bill, attempted 'Consolidate the different categories of *stridhana* into one single category of property and lay down the uniform rule of succession'

(ibid.: 7). In the same vein, he opposed dowry and was conscious of the treatment meted out to girls because of dowry. Therefore, while moving the Bill in the parliament, he opined,

All the members of the House know . . . how girls who bring an enormous lot of property . . . by way of dowry or *Stridhan* or gift are treated . . . with utter contempt, tyranny, and oppression (Ibid.: 8).

Therefore, Ambedkar mooted that,

property which is given as dowry . . . shall be treated as a trust property, the use of which will ensure to woman and . . . neither her husband nor the relations of her husband will have any interest in that property (Ibid.).

The provision of separate maintenance for the woman who lives away from her husband was also made by Ambedkar. The Bill recognized that there are circumstances where the wife has lived away from her husband, and she can claim separate maintenance from the husband. The following are conditions in which a wife can claim maintenance from her husband:

(1) suffering from a loathsome disease; (2) if a husband keeps a concubine; (3) if a husband is guilty of cruelty; (4) if a husband has abandoned her for two years; (5) if he has converted to another religion (Ibid.: 8-9).

As far as the Hindu marriage is concerned, he introduced the idea of civil marriage. He opined that the code would dispense with caste and sub-caste in the event of civil marriage. He argued, 'Marriage under this Bill be valid irrespective of the caste or sub-caste of the parties entering into marriage' (ibid.: 9). Furthermore, Ambedkar abolished polygamy, which was permissible under the existing Hindu Law. He argued, 'Under the new law, it is monogamy which is prescribed' (ibid.: 10). Ambedkar also introduced the provision to dismantle the sacramental status of the Hindu marriage in which it cannot be dissolved. He made it a contract by introducing

the provision of divorce. Ambedkar introduced seven grounds of divorce:

(1) desertion; (2) conversion to another religion; (3) keeping concubine or becoming a concubine; (4) incurably unsound mind; (5) a virulent and incurable form of leprosy; (6) venereal diseases in a communicable form; (7) cruelty (Ibid.: 10).

Addressing the question of adoption, 'under the code', he made the consent of the women necessary for the husband (Ibid.).

In this manner, Ambedkar envisaged to empower the Hindu women. It is pertinent to note here that the Indian parliament did not pass different clauses of the Hindu Code Bill tabled by Ambedkar, and he had to resign from the Nehru cabinet as the first Law Minister of independent India (ibid.: 1317-27). This is testimony to the fact of how much Ambedkar was committed to the cause of Indian women. It is heartening to note that, subsequently, most of the clauses proposed by Ambedkar in the Hindu Code were passed one-by-one by the Indian parliament.

FUTURE OF THE INDIAN NATION

Ambedkar not only explained the existing nature of the Indian society, defined the notion of a nation, why India is not a nation, and gave the scheme of national building, but he also gave five principles for keeping the Indian nation safe in the future. Ambedkar was aware of the Indian history of how the nation was colonized several times, and that is why he was concerned for the future of the nation. Following are the five principles for safeguarding the future of the Indian nation and society:

Self-introspection by the Indians.

Adherence to constitutional means.

Denunciation of hero worship.

Establishment of social and economic democracy, along with political democracy.

Changing government by the people to government for the people.

SELF-INTROSPECTION AND THE FUTURE OF THE NATION

The first and foremost principle suggested by Ambedkar to guard the future of the Indian nation is 'self-introspection' by the Indians. On the last day of the Constituent Assembly, 26 November 1949 when the Constitution of India was to be finally handed over to the President of India, he told the Constituent Assembly to have self-introspection. Ambedkar (1994: 1213-14) argued,

... my mind is so full of the future of our country. . . . On 26 January 1950, India will be an independent country (Cheers). What would happen to her independence? Will she maintain her independence, or will she lose it again? . . . It is not that India was never an independent country. The point is that she once lost the independence she had. Will she lose it a second time? It is this thought which makes me most anxious for the future. What perturbs me greatly is the fact that not only did India once lose her independence, but she lost it by the infidelity and treachery of some of our own people. In the invasion of Sind by Mahommed-bin-Kasim, the military commanders of King Dhar accepted bribes from the agents of Mahommed-bin-Kasim and refused to fight on the side of their King. It was Jaichand who invited Mahommed Ghori to invade India and fight against Prithvi Raj and promised him the help of himself and the Solanki kings. When Shivaji was fighting for the liberation of Hindus, the other Maratha noblemen and Rajput Kings were fighting the battle on the side of Mogul Emperors. When the

British were trying to destroy the Sikh Rulers, Gulab Singh, their principal commander, sat silent and did not help to save the Sikh kingdom. In 1857, when a large part of India declared a war of independence against the British, the Sikhs stood and watched the event as silent spectators.

Besides reminding the assembly of the drawbacks India had suffered in the historical past, Ambedkar highlighted the dangers of new enemies like new political parties with diverse and opposing political interests. Ambedkar (1994: 1215) cautioned the Assembly,

Will history repeat itself? . . . Will Indians place the country above their creed, or will they place the creed above the country? I do not know. But this much is certain if the parties place creed above country, our independence will be put in jeopardy a second time and probably be lost forever. This we must all resolutely guard against. We must be determined to defend our independence with the last drop of our blood. . . . What would happen to her democratic constitution? Will she be able to maintain it, or will she lose it again. . . . It is not that India did not know what democracy is. There was a time when India was studded with republics, and even where there were monarchies, they were either elected or limited. They were not absolute. It is not that India did not know parliaments or parliamentary procedure. A study of the Buddhist *Bhikkhu Sangha* discloses that not only were there parliaments, the *Sangha* were nothing but parliaments. The *Sangha* knew and observed all the rules of parliamentary Procedures known to modern times. . . . This democratic system India lost. Will she lose it a second time? I do not know, but it is quite possible in a country like India, where democracy from its long disuse must be regarded as something quite new—there is the danger of democracy giving place to dictatorship. It is quite possible for this newborn democracy to retain its form but give place to dictatorship becoming much greater.

ADHERENCE TO CONSTITUTIONAL MEANS

Further, Ambedkar's vision for keeping the future of Indian democracy intact included adherence to constitutional means as well. He emphasized,

If we wish to maintain democracy not merely in form, but also in fact, what we must do? The first thing . . . we must do is to hold fast to constitutional methods of achieving our social and economic objectives. It means we must abandon the bloody methods of revolution. It means that we must abandon the method of civil disobedience, non-cooperation, and *satyagraha*. When there was no way left for constitutional methods to achieve economic and social objectives, there was a great deal of justification for unconstitutional methods. But where constitutional methods are open, there can be no justification for these unconstitutional methods. These methods are nothing but anarchy and the sooner they are abandoned, the better for us (Ambedkar 1994: 1215).

DENUNCIATION OF HERO WORSHIP

Similarly, Ambedkar saw a threat to the future of democracy and, thereby, the nation because of hero worship. That is why he emphasized that

we must . . . observe the caution which John Stuart Mill has given to all who are interested in the maintenance of democracy, namely, not 'to lay their liberties at the feet of even a great man, or to trust him with powers which enable him to subvert their institutions (Ibid.: 1215).

Further, Ambedkar specifically warned against hero-worship (*bhakti*) in politics and also in journalism. According to him:

There is nothing wrong with being grateful to great men who have rendered life-long services to the country. But there are limits to gratefulness. As has been well said by the Irish Patriot Daniel

O'Connell, 'No man can be grateful at the cost of his honour, no woman can be grateful at the cost of her chastity, and no nation can be grateful at the cost of its liberty'. This caution is far more necessary in the case of India than in the case of any other country, for in India, *bhakti*, or what may be called the path of devotion or hero-worship, plays a part in its politics unequaled in magnitude by the part it plays in the politics of any other country in the world. *Bhakti* in religion may be the road to the salvation of the soul. But in politics, *bhakti* or hero-worship is a sure road to degradation and to eventual dictatorship (Ibid.: 1215).

As far as Indian journalism is concerned, Ambedkar had emphasized long back.

Journalism in India was once a profession. It now has become trade. . . . To accept a hero and worship has become its principal duty. . . . It is written by drum boys to glorify their heroes. Never has the interest of the country been sacrificed so senselessly for the propagation of hero-worship. Never has hero-worship become so blind as we see in India today (Ambedkar 1979: 227).

That is why Ambedkar suggested the first or foremost duty of Indian Journalism should be to,

Regard itself as the responsible advisor of the public. To give the news uncolored by any motive, to present a certain view of public policy which it believes to be for the good of the community, to correct and chastise without fear all those, no matter how high, who have chosen a wrong or a barren path (Ibid.: 227).

In this context, while criticizing both Gandhi and Jinnah, Ambedkar had also highlighted the biases of Congress Press. In this regard, he suggested that countrymen should understand,

. . . that the country is greater than the men, that the worship Mr Gandhi or Mr Jinnah, and service to India are two very different things and may even be contradictory to each other (Ibid.: 209).

DEMOCRACY SOCIAL, ECONOMIC,
AND POLITICAL

For strengthening the Indian nation and democracy, Ambedkar believed that we should not only be content with the establishment of political democracy, but rather we should stretch it to social and economic as well. Therefore, he emphasized that

We must . . . not . . . be content with mere political democracy. We must make our political democracy a social democracy as well. Political democracy cannot last unless there lies at the base of its social democracy (Ambedkar 1994: 1216).

Ambedkar went on to define social democracy as

. . . a way of life which recognizes liberty, equality, and fraternity as the principles of life. These principles of liberty, equality, and fraternity are not to be treated as separate items of a trinity (Ibid.).

In this context, Ambedkar's explanation of the nature of this trinity can be considered another decisive contribution. According to him,

They form a union of trinity in the sense that to divorce one from the other is to defeat the very purpose of democracy. Liberty cannot be divorced from equality; equality cannot be divorced from liberty. Nor can liberty and equality be divorced from fraternity. Without equality, liberty would produce the supremacy of the few over many. Equality without liberty would kill individual initiative. Without fraternity, liberty and equality could not become a natural course of things. . . . We must begin by acknowledging the fact that there is a complete absence of two things in Indian society. One of these is equality. On the social plane, we have in India a society based on the principle of graded inequality which means elevation of some and degradation of others. On the economic plane, we have a society in which there are some who have immense wealth as against many who live in abject poverty (Ibid.).

Therefore, Ambedkar stated that,

On the 26 January 1950, we are going to enter into a life of contradictions. In politics we will have equality and in social economic life we will have inequality. In Politics, we will be recognizing the principle of one man one vote, and one vote one value. In our social and economic life, we shall, by reason of our social and economic structure, continue to live this life of contradiction. How long shall we continue to live this life of contradictions? If we continue to deny it for long, we will do so only by putting our political democracy in peril. We must remove this contradiction at the earliest possible moment or else those who suffer from inequality will blow up the structure of political democracy (Ambedkar 1994: 1216-17).

Ambedkar, for establishing social democracy, emphasized the following:

The second thing we want is recognition of the principle of fraternity. What does fraternity mean? Fraternity means a sense of common brotherhood of Indians—if Indians are one people. It is the principle that gives unity and solidarity to social life. . . . The realization of this goal is going to be very difficult. . . . In India there are castes. The castes are anti-national . . . because they bring about separation in social life . . . also . . . generate jealousy and antipathy. . . . But we must overcome all these difficulties if we wish to become a nation in reality. For fraternity can be a fact only when there is a nation (Ibid.).

About the above discussion on equality, liberty, and fraternity, it will be worth mentioning the source from which he borrowed these principles of democracy. He argues that he has not borrowed them from the French Revolution; rather, he has borrowed them from Buddhism. In his own words,

Every man should have a philosophy of life, for everyone must have a standard by which to measure his conduct. And philosophy is nothing but a standard by which to measure. . . . Positively, my philosophy. May be said to be enshrined in three words: Equality,

Liberty, and Fraternity. Let no one, however, say that I have borrowed my philosophy from the French Revolution. I have not. My philosophy has roots in religion and not in political science. I have derived them from my Master, the Buddha. In his philosophy, liberty and equality had a place; but he added that unlimited Liberty destroyed equality and absolute equality left no room for liberty. In his philosophy, Law had a place only as a safeguard against the breaches of Liberty and Equality; but he did not believe that law can be a guarantee for breaches of Liberty and Equality. He gave the highest place to the fraternity as the only real safeguard against the denial of liberty or equality or fraternity, which was another name for brotherhood or humanity, which was again another name for religion (Ambedkar 2003: 503).

FROM GOVERNMENT BY THE PEOPLE TO GOVERNMENT FOR THE PEOPLE

Last but not least, to keep the future of our nation safe, the political elite should strive to change the nature of the government from 'Government by the people' to 'Government for the people'. It was important to do so because Ambedkar thought that political power in this country had too long been the monopoly of the few. This monopolization of politics by a minority has deprived the downtrodden of the chances of their betterment; it has also sapped them of the significance of their lives (Ambedkar 1994: 2017-18). Therefore, he emphasized,

These downtrodden classes are tired of being governed. They are impatient to govern themselves. This urge for self-realization in the downtrodden classes must not be allowed into a class struggle or class war. It would lead to a division of the House. That would be a day of disaster. For, as has been well said by Abraham Lincoln, a house divided against itself cannot stand very long. Therefore, the sooner the room is made for the realization of their aspiration, the better for the few, the better for the country, the better for the

maintenance of its independence, and the better for the continuance of its democratic structure. This can only be done by the establishment of equality and fraternity in all spheres of life.

Ambedkar cautioned that after Independence it has thrown great responsibility on citizens of the country. We have to meet the aspirations of the people:

People are fast changing. People . . . are being moved by new ideologies. They are getting tired of the government by the people. They are prepared to have a Government for the people. . . . If we wish to preserve the Constitution in which we have sought to enshrine in principle of Government of the people, for the people, and by the people, let us resolve not to be tardy in the recognition of the evils that lie across our path and which induce people to prefer Government for the people to Government by the people, nor to be weak in our initiative to remove them. That is the only way to serve the country (Ambedkar 1994: 1218).

CONCLUSION

In the light of the detailed aforementioned discussion and explanation, we can argue safely that Ambedkar was the only leader of his times who tried to argue, based on empirical facts, that India is not a nation rather a nation in the making. Based on empirical reality, Ambedkar also tried to explain why India was not a nation. Third, he defined what exactly he means by a nation. Fourth, he presented an alternative process of nation building.

We have also observed in the discussion that Ambedkar adhered to the notion of the nation based on both sentiments and also based on objective conditions of deprivation. Therefore, he differentiated between nationality and nationalism. He also underlined the fact that without the nation, there will not be fraternity, and in the absence of fraternity, equality, and liberty

will not be the reality. He held that fraternity, equality, and liberty are interconnected and interdependent. However, he treated fraternity on a higher pedestal than equality and liberty.

Further, apart from making people realize that India is not a nation Ambedkar tried to make people realize that there can be five very significant ways through which we can build a nation. These were—forgetfulness, freedom of the servile classes, breaking the monopoly of the governing classes and allowing self-representation to the excluded groups. Besides, Ambedkar also pleaded that a nation cannot be built without establishing the rights of various sections of society that comprised it, especially the rights of the erstwhile servile classes. In this regard, he pleaded for the self-representation of ex-untouchables (Dalits), Other Backward Castes, Tribals, religious minorities and women. In this sense we can accept a nation as an idea of emancipation for the people suffering double disadvantage one that of a colonialism and two that of a caste ridden hierarchical society.

Along with the analysis of the notion of nation as propounded by Ambedkar, this chapter has also discussed five principles to keep the future of our nation safe as have been discussed by Ambedkar in his thoughts. These five principles are self-introspection by the Indians, adherence to constitutional means, denunciation of hero worship in politics, the establishment of social and economic democracy along with political democracy, and last, but not least, changing government by people to government for the people. In this way, we have engaged with Ambedkar's idea of nation and nation building. By doing so, we have engaged with another aspect of his knowledge production and have tried to deconstruct the process of reduction of his persona, life, and mission to a leader belonging to a particular identity.

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Conclusion

The facts, narratives, and debates in the preceding chapters of the book have successfully established that Ambedkar has been the victim of reductionism, erasure, and stigmatization. We have proved this based on an analysis of historical, sociological, and literary books and texts written by journalists. The erasure of Ambedkar from the creative field, like the Richard Attenborough directed epic film *Gandhi*, and the intrusion of Gandhi in the Jabbar Patel directed film *Ambedkar* further prove the point of reductionism of Ambedkar. However, we are aware that the empirical data for the aforementioned discourse may not look exhaustive, but it is just enough to put the point in perspective.

The available empirical data has helped us to highlight the fact that academia, intelligentsia, and media persons have contributed their bit to the aforementioned processes surrounding Ambedkar. A point to be noted here is that Ambedkar has been taken here only as a representative case to understand the discourse on how icons belonging to marginalized sections of Indian society have been victims of the same processes as Ambedkar. If that is true, then the book suggests that we should engage ourselves in analysis of the impact of such processes surrounding the marginalized sections of Indian society.

Against the processes of reductionism, erasure, and stigmatization, the book explores how Babasaheb's academic works have been received and acknowledged by international institutions and scholars across the globe. The book has probed how, on the one

hand, the foreigners have engaged with Babasaheb Ambedkar's writings on several issues—social, political, religious, constitutional, democracy, and Social Justice, to name just a few. We can see that there is a string of Western social and political scientists like—Owen M. Lynch, Eleanor Zelliot, Gail Omvedt, John C.B. Webster, Simon R. Charsley, Christopher S. Queen, Maren Bellwinkel Schempp (see Ram 2008), Barbara R Joshi, Christopher Jaffrelot, Perry Anderson, and Cosimo Zene, to name just a few, who have engaged with his theoretical, philosophical formulations and social movements from a universalistic perspective.

On the other hand, we have also observed how Ambedkar's busts have been installed in various universities in the UK, USA, Canada, Australia, Japan, and Vietnam, which proves the point that his life and mission are being celebrated in those countries. Memorial lectures instituted in his name in various foreign universities substantiate the aforesaid point further. If there is any doubt regarding the acceptance of his greatness, then the description of his persona in the citation letter of his L.L.D. degree ends the debate. In this citation, he is addressed as 'a framer of the constitution . . . a great social reformer and valiant upholder of human rights.' In the same vein, Anderson (2012: 56) praised him by treating him 'intellectually head and shoulder above most of the Congress leaders'. On the intellectual plane, Anderson eulogized his book *Pakistan or Partition of India* in no uncertain terms by emphasizing the fact that the book, ' . . . stands as a devastating indictment of intellectual poverty of Congress and its leaders' (2012: 89).

Jaffrelot (2005) treats Ambedkar as a sociologist who 'confronted head on Western authors at the age of twenty-five'. Jaffrelot, who was interested in Ambedkar's sociological thoughts, was introduced to Ambedkar by another fellow French anthropologist, Oliver Herrenschmidt, who was in Paris. In his

acknowledgments, Jaffrelot accepted that 'I gradually discovered that he (Ambedkar) played a pioneering role in the sociology of India'. However, he felt that 'Dr. Ambedkar remained one of modern India's most neglected public figures'. That is why he emphasizes that 'I decided to write this book, first of all, to do justice to a then marginalized key personality of Indian History'. Jaffrelot also accepts that while writing his book, he benefited from the erudite insights of American historian Zelliott (see Zelliott 2001) and American anthropologist Lynch (see Lynch 1974) on Ambedkar. These examples are enough to prove the point that how Western scholars have accepted Ambedkar's academic depth and strength to understand different types of particularistic and universalistic facts.

Apart from highlighting the paradox surrounding Ambedkar's persona and his production of knowledge, the discourse in the book also underlines the proper framework to understand the functioning of several institutions in Indian society. For example, if one wants to understand the caste system of India, one cannot understand it, according to Ambedkar, as an isolated and independent unit. Ambedkar's scheme is unique. It begins with the individual's place in the Hindu social order. Then, he analyses it and declares that it is not a free social order as it makes the individual dependent on his *varna*. Then, he defines the origin and nature of *varna* with the help of both *Rigveda* and *Yajurveda* (*White Yajurveda* and *Black Yajurveda*). Further, Ambedkar, with the help of his unique anthropological and sociological methodology, defines the origin of caste. The discourse on caste is his original theory which includes the imposition of endogamy over exogamy and the propositions of 'surplus man' and 'surplus women'.

A related corollary to this discourse is the relationship between caste and subjugation of Hindu women. Ambedkar opines the emergence of practices like Sati, girl marriage, and enforced

widowhood was the result of the maintenance of the caste system (Ambedkar 1979: 13). In a way, Ambedkar proves the point that patriarchy and caste are intertwined. Lastly, Ambedkar's proposition of the spread of castes across Indian society is also innovative. He uses Tarde's law of imitation for the spread of the caste across Indian society, which is very different in comparison to mainstream sociological theories that hold Manu and *Manusmriti* responsible for the spread of caste in India, specifically, Manu's *varnasankara* theory.

After this, logically, the discourse on the caste system should have included the emergence of Shudra and untouchables as well. However, we have not included that here because the focus of the book is different. Finally, we should also include the *Annihilation of Caste* in this framework of understanding the caste system in India. But we should understand that the Annihilation of the caste system should not be treated as an isolated exercise and end. Also, reading *Annihilation of Caste* does not mean one has understood Ambedkar and his philosophy in totality. I am underlining this point here because I have observed that many students, researchers, faculty members, journalists, and even bureaucrats boast that they have read and understood Ambedkar if they have read *Annihilation of Caste*.

The book, then, relates to the discourse of Hindu social order with 'Social Justice'. It is pertinent to engage with the concept of social justice because Ambedkar has not given any specific theory of social justice in the caste-ridden society. Yet, drawing an analogy with Plato and John Rawls, we can find several tenets of social justice in the writings and speeches of Ambedkar, which were published posthumously by the then Government of Maharashtra. In this context, Ambedkar has highlighted the unique features of the Hindu social order that no Indian or Western sociologists of repute have identified and analysed. To disseminate social justice in society, Ambedkar opined that society

must be based on equality, liberty, and fraternity. For him, inequality in the Hindu social order is not simple; rather, it is graded inequality. Again, this is a unique formulation that no sociologists have discovered.

Discourse on the nation and the notion of nation building, according to Ambedkar, is also related to establishing equality, liberty, and fraternity. The trinity cannot be divorced from each other, he adds. However, Ambedkar asserts that he has not drawn this proposition from the 'French Revolution' rather, he has borrowed it from Buddhism. It is so because, according to Ambedkar, in Buddhist formulation, 'fraternity' assumes prominence over equality and liberty. We can make a law for liberty and equality; however, we cannot make a law for 'fraternity', he asserts. Establishing fraternity is a very critical characteristic of nation building. The annihilation of the caste system reappears again in Babasaheb's scheme of nation building. He emphasized that a society divided into thousands of castes cannot be a nation. castes breed animosity and jealousy among the people. Hence, Ambedkar argued for nation building, we must mitigate social divisions among Hindus and Dalits, Hindus and tribals, and Hindus and Muslims. We have observed that Ambedkar's theory of nation building is reconciliation between Mauss's 'Primordialist Theory' and Gellner's 'Institutional Theory' (Jafferlot 2002). For nation building, Ambedkar not only demanded the establishment of equality, liberty, and fraternity via annihilating caste differences among the different social communities, but he also asked to establish the rights of every marginalized section of society, especially the Dalits, Tribals, Other Backward Castes, Minorities, and women.

By now, we are aware that Babasaheb was not in favour of the abrupt Partition of the country. Can it not be considered that it was because of nation building? He had a different scheme to solve the Hindu-Muslim dispute by creating two federations—

Hindustan and Pakistan, under one strong central government. He wanted that these federations should be given at least ten years to function. Babasaheb believed that after governing their affairs for a decade, Hindus and Muslims would realize that a united India would be better for both. They will develop confidence in each other. We are aware that in his book *Pakistan or Partition of India*, he uses the definition of Renan, and argues that race, language, and country do not suffice to build a nation.

Ambedkar defined the nation as a 'living soul and a spiritual principle'. The nation, like the individual, is the outcome of a long past of efforts, sacrifices, and devotion. That is why Anderson (2012: 89) acknowledged Ambedkar's vision in the following words,

Ambedkar alone was early on clear-sighted. . . . In 1944, at a time when the very idea of it was taboo in Congress and still more than a vague slogan in the Muslim League itself, he published the only serious work on the issue that would determine the outcome of the struggle for independence. . . . Critical to Muslim introversion, alert to Savarkar's Hindutva, contemptuous to the myth of pan-religious amity, Ambedkar did not advocate separation of two communities.

However, Ambedkar's profound wisdom and referential knowledge have been erased in the annals of Indian academics.

The discourse in the book surrounding Ambedkar's larger concerns in the production of his knowledge, like Hindu social order, social justice, democracy, or nation building, rather than restricted to the analysis of caste only, has underlined another fact, along with many others. That is reductionism and contraction of the thought processes of Dalits to the analysis of the caste system in academics. We have observed that the Dalit academicians have restricted themselves, to a large extent, in the university system in teaching, debating, and researching the caste system since Independence. However, we have not seen any significant progress

in reducing its impact and intensity; rather, caste has changed its nature and the catchment area and has become more subtle and sophisticated.

Parallel to the aforesaid caste discourse in which Dalits are 'trapped', the so-called upper castes have incorporated the *varnal* caste system in academics without any criticality and reflexivity (Kumar 2016). It seems that they have done so to maintain the status quo. Instead of engaging critically with *Rigveda*, Purush Sukta, the tenth *mandala* theory of caste, they have accepted it, as it is in toto. Further, to strengthen its structure, they have adopted a functionalist model and added concepts like *jajmani* and Sanskritization to the caste system, as well. In this way, the caste has been given sanctity and legitimacy in academics. A natural corollary to this development is that through this status quoist engagement of caste, the so-called upper-castes have maintained their caste superiority and hegemony in society. If that is true, then how can we annihilate caste or bring substantial change in the caste system and caste-ridden society where people do not have 'Consciousness of Kind', but caste consciousness? (Ambedkar 1979).

To undermine the legitimacy extended to caste by the so-called upper caste and to challenge their superiority and hegemony in academia and, thereby, in society, Dalits must come out of the ghetto and rut of caste studies. Dalits will have to herald a new chapter in the academic arena for their emancipation and, thereby, the emancipation of the whole society.

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ANNEXURE I

Columbia University
in the City of New York

BHIMRAO RAMJI AMBEDKAR, LL.D.

Born in India and schooled there under heavy handicaps; B.A. of the University of Bombay at twenty, and for three years a graduate student in this University, receiving the doctorate in political science; subsequently a student of the Inns of Court and the University of London, obtaining a doctorate in economics; for the past three decades as barrister, university professor, and member of the legislative council, as a framer of the Constitution, member of the cabinet and of the Council of State, one of India's leading citizens--a great social reformer and a valiant upholder of human rights.

In the exercise of the authority conferred upon me by the Trustees, I gladly admit you to the degree of Doctor of Laws, honoris causa, in this University and confer upon you all the rights and privileges which attach thereto, in token whereof I hand you this diploma.



Grayson Kirk
Vice President and Provost

June 5, 1952

ANNEXURE II

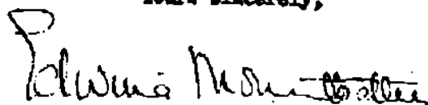
Dear Mr. Ambedkar,

I congratulate you for the Post of chairmanship of
Drafting committee of the constitution. Mr. Valara
has recommended your name and everyone is sure about your
brilliance and everyone from this country believes in your
Patriotism.

I am personally glad to see you supervising the
constitution as you are the only genius who can give equal
justice to every class and creed. I have been your long time admirer
and hoping you will fulfill your duty towards the country.

I wish you every success in your work.

Yours sincerely,



Dr Ambedkar

Rajghat Hindu Colony

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